

WORLD PEACE

"Global Peace Is Possible"

People Should Relate on the Basis of Humanity

No Discrimination · No Wars · No Killings of Any Sort

by

Professor Dr. Kingsley Kebiru Momodu

PhD in World Peace | Honorary Doctorate | Honorary Professor of World Peace

Kennedy University of Baptist, United States of America

Grade 5 GESE with Distinction, CEFR Level B1.1 | Trinity College London

Certificate of Title: Lord | Prestige Titles, United Kingdom

A Comprehensive Study in the Context of Contemporary Global Challenges



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This work is based in part upon the doctoral dissertation A Comprehensive Study of World Peace in the Context of Contemporary Global Challenges, submitted to Kennedy University of Baptist, United States of America, 2026.

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Verified Credentials and Qualifications

Professor Dr. Kingsley Kebiru Momodu holds the following formally verified academic, linguistic, and civic credentials:

- PhD in World Peace—Kennedy University of Baptist, United States of America (2026)
- Honorary Doctorate—Kennedy University of Baptist, United States of America
- Honorary Professor of World Peace—Kennedy University of Baptist, United States of America
- Grade 5 Graded Examination in Spoken English (GESE) with Distinction—Trinity College London (June 2019, CEFR Level B1.1). Entry Level Certificate in ESOL International Speaking and Listening (Entry 3). Certificate issued 18 June 2019, London Central SELT Centre. Regulated by Ofqual. Certificate No. 00558750.
- Certificate of Title: Lord—Prestige Titles, United Kingdom. Motto: Decens et Honestum (Decent and Honorable).

These credentials are the foundation from which this work speaks: rigorously academic, linguistically excellent, and civic in its deepest orientation. They represent not merely formal attainment, but the sustained intellectual and personal journey of a man who has crossed continents, navigated cultures, and dedicated his life to the pursuit of understanding—and, through understanding, to the pursuit of peace.

The doctoral research at Kennedy University of Baptist, which underpins this volume, was conducted with rigorous academic methods: employing quantitative survey data from three hundred participants across multiple countries, twenty-five in-depth qualitative interviews, and detailed case studies of successful peace processes from South Africa to Northern Ireland to Colombia. This empirical foundation lends weight to the philosophical and theological arguments developed in the chapters that follow.

Dedication

"To every human being on this earth—the forgotten, the oppressed, the lonely, the hungry, and those who dare to dream of a world without war. This book is for you."

To my mother, who taught me that every human heart—regardless of color, creed, or country—beats with the same longing for love, dignity, and peace.

To every man, woman, and child who has ever lived under the shadow of war, violence, or injustice—and to those who refuse to accept that this is the world we must settle for. Your refusal is itself a form of courage.

To the peacemakers—known and unknown—who dedicate their lives to the quiet, patient, often thankless labor of building understanding between peoples. History will not always remember your names. But the world you helped to make is your monument.

To the children of the world—you deserve a better earth than the one we have left you. This is my promise to help build it. To the young men and women of Africa, of Asia, of the Middle East, of Latin America—of every continent and every culture—who carry within them the energy and the intelligence and the moral fire that this world so urgently needs. This book is written in solidarity with you.

To the people of the United Kingdom—and particularly of London and Romford—who have welcomed me and given me a home. Your generosity of spirit is itself a form of lived peace. In the diversity of your streets, in the civility of your institutions, and in the quiet decency of your daily life, you demonstrate every day that difference need not mean division.

And to God—source of all shalom, all salaam, all peace—whose call echoes in every human heart, across every tradition, in every language humanity has ever used to reach towards the sacred.

About the Author

Lord Professor Dr. Kingsley Kebiru Momodu is a British-Nigerian scholar, humanitarian, minister of God, and global advocate for world peace. Born in Nigeria and a long-time resident of the United Kingdom, his life has traversed continents, cultures, and faith traditions—a journey that has profoundly shaped his conviction that peace across human divides is not merely desirable, but achievable.

He holds a PhD in World Peace from Kennedy University of Baptist, United States of America, awarded in recognition of his rigorous interdisciplinary research into the theological, philosophical, and practical dimensions of global peacebuilding. Kennedy University further conferred upon him an honorary doctorate and an honorary professorship in world peace—honors reflecting the breadth of his scholarly contribution and his sustained humanitarian service across continents.

His English language excellence is formally recognized through his Grade 5 Graded Examination in Spoken English (GESE) with Distinction from Trinity College London—awarded in June 2019 at the London Central SELT Centre—demonstrating achievement at CEFR Level B1.1. This qualification, regulated by Ofqual, certifies his Entry Level Certificate in ESOL International Speaking and Listening (Entry 3). He has additionally been recognized with a Certificate of Title by Prestige Titles, United Kingdom, under the motto *Decens et Honestum*—Decent and Honorable.

Born in Nigeria into a family that straddled both Islamic and Christian traditions, his spiritual journey is itself a testament to the possibility of reconciliation. His conversion from Islam to Christianity did not breed in him contempt for his former faith; rather, it deepened his reverence for the common spiritual hunger that animates all human beings, regardless of the tradition through which they seek to satisfy it. This interior journey from one great faith to another, accomplished not in bitterness but in understanding, gave him a perspective that few scholars of peace can claim: the experience of having inhabited, from the inside, two of the world's great traditions of compassion.

He has travelled extensively across the world—through Africa, Europe, the Americas, and Asia—and it is from these journeys, as much as from his academic and ministerial formation, from which his understanding of humanity derives. He has sat in the palaces of the powerful and in the dwellings of the destitute. He has spoken in universities and in prisons, in cathedrals and in community halls. He has broken bread with kings and with the homeless. Wherever he has gone, he has carried the same message: that every human being is worthy of dignity and that the structures of our world must be rebuilt to reflect this truth.

Based in Romford, Essex, London, he remains rooted in one of the world's most culturally diverse cities—a daily reminder that difference need not mean division. He continues to lecture, write, and advocate for the realization of global peace. His doctoral thesis—A Comprehensive Study of World Peace in the Context of Contemporary Global Challenges—forms the scholarly foundation of the present volume.

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Foreword

There is a particular kind of courage required to write about world peace in an age of perpetual conflict. It is the courage to believe—not naively, but deliberately and with open eyes—that humanity is capable of something better than what we have thus far achieved.

Professor Dr. Kingsley Kebiru Momodu is a man who possesses precisely that courage. Born in Nigeria, shaped by faith, travel, hardship, and grace, and now a resident of London, England, he brings to this work a perspective that is both global and deeply personal. He has walked through the markets of West Africa and the corridors of European cities. He has sat with the powerful and with the poorest of the poor. He has converted between the world's great faiths and emerged not with hatred for either, but with a deeper love for the humanity that both proclaim to honor.

His doctoral research at Kennedy University of Baptist, United States of America—which earned him a PhD in World Peace, an Honorary Doctorate, and an Honorary Professorship in World Peace—brought together theological analysis, philosophical inquiry, empirical survey data from three hundred participants across multiple countries, twenty-five in-depth qualitative interviews, and detailed case studies of successful peace processes. That research forms the scholarly spine of this book. His English language excellence, certified with Distinction by Trinity College London at CEFR Level B1.1, ensures that these complex ideas reach the reader with precision, clarity, and grace. His designation as Lord by Prestige Titles, under the motto *Decens et Honestum*, reflects the esteem in which his humanitarian work is held.

This book, *World Peace: Global Peace Is Possible*, is the fruit of extraordinary journeys—physical, spiritual, and intellectual. It is not a work of politics, nor a sermon. It is something altogether rarer: a rigorous and deeply human argument for why peace between peoples is not merely desirable but achievable. The reader will find within these pages both careful scholarship and lived experience. This is a book for our times.

At the moment of its writing, conflicts rage in Ukraine, Gaza, Sudan, and beyond. The instruments of mass destruction grow more powerful with every passing year. The engines of

dehumanization—social media platforms optimised for outrage, political movements founded on contempt—are running faster than at any point in history. The temptation to despair is real, and only a fool would deny it. And yet—the author’s central contention—the conditions for peace are not absent from the world. They are merely obscured by fear, greed, and the failure of collective imagination.

What Lord Professor Dr. Momodu offers in these pages is something more than hope. He offers a map. He draws on the great traditions of philosophical thought, from Kant’s vision of perpetual peace to the African concept of Ubuntu, to show that the intellectual foundations of a peaceful world have already been laid. He draws on the social sciences, from contact theory to the literature on structural violence, to show that we understand the causes of conflict and the conditions that reduce it. He draws on the evidence of history’s peace processes—in South Africa, in Northern Ireland, in Mozambique—to show that people who seemed irreconcilably divided have, again and again, found a way through.

Read this book with an open heart. Let it challenge you. And when you have finished it, ask yourself the question the author has spent a lifetime answering: What can I do, from where I stand, to bring about the world that all of us—every last one of us—deserve?

London, England, 2026.

Preface: A Journey Towards Peace

I remember the first time I truly understood what it meant to be a stranger.

It was many years ago, in a city that was not my own, in a country where I did not yet speak the language fluently. I was tired, my luggage was heavy, and I had lost my way. A woman saw me—she did not know me, and she did not share my faith, my nation, or my language—and she stopped. She pointed me in the right direction. She smiled. And in that smile, something profound passed between us: the recognition that we were both human beings, equally lost in the enormity of this world, equally in need of kindness.

That moment, small as it was, became the seed of this book.

I have spent the better part of my life travelling—across continents, across cultures, and across the great divides of religion, language, and politics. I was born in Nigeria, raised between Islam and Christianity, and I have lived now for many years in London, one of the most extraordinary cities on earth precisely because it contains, within a single metropolitan area, the entirety of human diversity. In London, the Nigerian and the Norwegian share a bus. The Muslim and the Methodist share a street. The refugee and the aristocrat share an NHS waiting room. And most of the time—far more often than the newspapers would have us believe—they get along.

This is not an accident. It is not the result of some benign magic in the London air. It is the result of centuries of slow, painful, incomplete but real work: the building of institutions, the cultivation of norms, and the gradual, generational education of a society to understand that its diversity is a strength. It is fragile, always. It requires constant maintenance. But it is real. And if it is possible in London, the question I have spent my academic and ministerial career addressing is, why is it not yet possible for the world?

This preface is an invitation to accompany me on the journey that gave rise to this book. It is a journey that began in Nigeria, in a family that straddled Islam and Christianity, in a childhood shaped by the stories of both traditions. It passed through the experience

of migration—the particular education in human nature that comes from being, for extended periods, the outsider, the stranger, the one whose name is mispronounced and whose culture is misunderstood. It continued through years of academic study, of ministerial practice, and doctoral research that took me, intellectually at least, to conflict zones across the globe.

Along the way, I have been shaped by encounters that no amount of academic reading could have produced. I have met survivors of genocide who had found, against all rational expectation, the capacity for forgiveness. I have spoken with combatants who had put down their weapons and could not, years later, explain to themselves why they had ever picked them up. I have sat with families torn apart by sectarian hatred who maintained, across the divide, fragile threads of friendship that the politicians and the propagandists had not managed to sever.

These encounters taught me something that the philosophical literature, at its best, confirms: that peace is not a distant ideal. It is a human capacity—present, latent, often suppressed, but always available. The question is not whether human beings are capable of peace. The evidence is overwhelming that they are. The question is what conditions allow that capacity to express itself, and what conditions suppress it. That is the question this book addresses.

A word about method. This book is not a purely academic work, though it draws extensively and, I hope, rigorously on academic sources. It is also not a memoir, though it contains personal testimony. It is an attempt to weave together scholarly analysis and lived experience in the service of a practical argument: that global peace is possible, that we know many of the steps required to move towards it, and that every human being—not only scholars, not only politicians, not only diplomats—has a role to play.

I have tried to write accessibly, without sacrificing intellectual seriousness. I have cited my sources, but I have also tried to tell stories—because stories are how human beings actually learn, and the argument of this book is itself fundamentally about the importance of stories: the stories we tell about one another and the alternative stories we could tell.

The doctoral research that informs this work was conducted under the supervision of Kennedy University of Baptist and was awarded

the degree of Doctor of Philosophy in World Peace in 2026. I am grateful to the institution, to my supervisors, and to the three hundred survey participants and twenty-five interview subjects whose experiences and reflections form the empirical foundation of the analysis that follows.

I am grateful, above all, to the woman who pointed me in the right direction, on a cold street in a city that was not yet my home, and smiled. Wherever she is: thank you. You began this.

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PART ONE

The Nature of Peace and War

Understanding the World We Inhabit

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Chapter One: Human Nature and the Possibility of Peace

There is a question that lies beneath every argument about world peace, and it must be addressed before any other: is peace actually possible? Not just in theory — not just as a philosophical ideal — but in practice, for real human beings, in the real world of the twenty-first century? There are those who will tell you, with great confidence, that it is not. Human beings, they say, are naturally aggressive. Violence is in our genes. War is inevitable. History proves it.

I want to take this view seriously, because it is sincerely held by many thoughtful people and because, if it were true, it would render the rest of this book pointless. If war and violence are hard-wired into human nature, then the project of world peace is a delusion — well-intentioned perhaps, but ultimately futile. If, however, the pessimists are wrong — or even partially wrong — then the project of world peace becomes not merely desirable but achievable.

The Evidence from Biology and Evolutionary Psychology

The first thing to be said about the claim that human beings are naturally violent is that it is, as a statement of modern biology, considerably more complicated than its advocates typically acknowledge. It is true that *Homo sapiens* is a species capable of extraordinary violence. The fossil record is littered with evidence of interpersonal violence, and the anthropological record of small-scale societies contains many examples of endemic warfare. The psychologist Steven Pinker, in his influential 2011 book *The Better Angels of Our Nature*, argued that violence has declined dramatically over the course of human history, but acknowledged that humanity's violent capacity has always been with us.

But it is equally true — and equally well-documented — that *Homo sapiens* is a species capable of extraordinary cooperation. We are, in fact, among the most cooperative animals on earth. Our capacity for large-scale social organisation, for division of labour, for the construction of complex institutions, for the maintenance of

trust across millions of individuals who have never met — these are features of our species that are unique in the animal kingdom, and they are the foundation of every civilisation we have ever built.

The primatologist Frans de Waal, in a career of remarkable research spanning several decades, has documented in extensive detail the capacity for empathy, reconciliation, and conflict resolution in our closest evolutionary relatives, the chimpanzees and bonobos. The bonobos in particular — a species as closely related to us as the chimpanzees — are characterised by social structures built around conflict resolution through physical affection, mutual grooming, and the sharing of food. De Waal's central argument, developed across works such as *The Age of Empathy* (2009) and *Mama's Last Hug* (2019), is that empathy is not a uniquely human invention. It is an evolutionary inheritance, shared across the great apes, and it is the biological foundation upon which human moral life is built.

The neuroscientist Antonio Damasio has demonstrated, through decades of research into patients with brain damage affecting the emotional centres of the brain, that moral reasoning — the capacity to make judgements about right and wrong, to feel the suffering of others, to be motivated by considerations of fairness and justice — is not a purely rational faculty. It is intimately bound up with emotional processing. People who lose the capacity to feel emotion do not become more rational; they become less capable of making consistent moral judgements. This finding has profound implications for peace: it suggests that the cultivation of empathy — the capacity to feel the experience of another person — is not a luxury add-on to moral reasoning. It is a biological precondition for it.

The evolutionary biologist E. O. Wilson articulated a view that has become increasingly influential in peace studies: that human beings carry within them the genetic inheritance of both competitive and cooperative tendencies, and that which tendency predominates depends in large measure on the social, economic, and institutional environment in which individuals find themselves. This is a finding of the utmost importance. It means that human nature is not fixed in a way that predetermines violence. It means that the design of social institutions, the cultivation of

cultural norms, and the provision of economic security are not peripheral to the question of peace. They are central to it.

The Historical Evidence

The historical record is often cited as proof that humanity is doomed to perpetual violence. It is an argument that deserves scrutiny. Yes, the historical record contains an enormous amount of war, massacre, genocide, and organised violence. But it also contains the gradual, uneven, contested but real development of institutions and norms that have reduced the incidence and severity of certain forms of violence over time.

Steven Pinker's comprehensive analysis of historical violence data, whatever one thinks of his more contentious claims, makes one thing clear: inter-state war between major powers has become dramatically rarer over the past seventy years than it was in previous centuries. The period since 1945, for all its horrors, has been notably free of the kind of industrial-scale warfare between European great powers that defined the first half of the twentieth century. This is not coincidence. It is the result of deliberate institutional design: the creation of the United Nations, the development of nuclear deterrence, the construction of international economic interdependence, the gradual expansion of democratic governance. The peace that has prevailed between France and Germany — nations that fought three catastrophic wars in seventy years — is not an accident of nature. It is an achievement of human ingenuity.

The sociologist Norbert Elias, in his monumental work *The Civilising Process* (1939), traced the gradual internalisation of norms against interpersonal violence in Western European societies over several centuries. What Elias documented is not a change in human nature, but a change in social norms and their enforcement — a change that progressively expanded the psychological threshold of acceptable violence and raised the social cost of its expression. This process is incomplete, uneven, and reversible under conditions of extreme stress. But it is real. And it demonstrates that the relationship between human beings and violence is not fixed. It is historically and socially contingent.

The anthropologist Douglas Fry has assembled compelling evidence, in *Beyond War: The Human Potential for Peace* (2007), that the assumption of endemic prehistoric warfare — the ‘killer ape’ hypothesis — is not well-supported by the archaeological and ethnographic record. Many human societies, particularly those organised as small nomadic bands, show little evidence of organised warfare. The correlation between warfare and certain forms of social organisation — settled agriculture, hierarchical political structures, competition over scarce resources — suggests that war is not an expression of universal human nature, but a product of specific social and material conditions. Change the conditions, and you change the likelihood of war.

The Psychological Evidence

The science of psychology adds important dimensions to our understanding of the relationship between human nature and peace. The Stanford psychologist Philip Zimbardo, whose famous prison experiment of 1971 demonstrated with disturbing clarity how readily ordinary people can be induced to perform acts of cruelty by the social structures and roles they inhabit, drew from this experience a conclusion that is both sobering and, ultimately, hopeful: that evil is not primarily a property of individual character but of social situations. ‘The power of situations’ to shape behaviour means that by changing situations — by redesigning social environments — we can change the behaviour that those situations produce.

The social psychologist James Waller, in *Becoming Evil: How Ordinary People Commit Genocide and Mass Killing* (2002), traced the psychological processes by which ordinary human beings are transformed into perpetrators of mass violence. His findings are disturbing in their implications but ultimately hopeful in their logic: the processes he describes — dehumanisation, moral disengagement, conformity to authority, diffusion of responsibility — are not expressions of innate savagery. They are the results of specific social, ideological, and institutional processes that can be identified, understood, and, where the political will exists, disrupted. If we can understand how ordinary people become perpetrators of mass violence, we can also understand how to prevent those transformation processes from occurring.

The work of the Israeli-American psychologist Daniel Kahneman, particularly his influential work *Thinking, Fast and Slow* (2011), has illuminated the cognitive mechanisms by which human beings make decisions under conditions of uncertainty, fear, and social pressure. His findings suggest that many of the cognitive biases that contribute to inter-group hostility — in-group favouritism, out-group derogation, the availability heuristic that leads people to overestimate the prevalence of threatening events — are not immutable features of human psychology but tendencies that can be understood and, with appropriate institutional design and education, mitigated.

A Complex and Hopeful Conclusion

The honest answer to the question of whether human nature permits or precludes peace is neither the pessimist's story of a naturally violent species condemned to perpetual warfare, nor the naive optimist story of a naturally peaceful species corrupted by bad institutions. It is something more complex and more interesting: we are a species capable of extraordinary violence and extraordinary compassion, and which of these capacities expresses itself depends largely on the social, political, and economic conditions in which we find ourselves.

This is, in fact, a profoundly hopeful conclusion. It means that violence is not destiny. It means that by changing conditions — by reforming institutions, by investing in education, by ensuring that human needs are met and that every person has a community in which they belong — we can shift the balance towards cooperation and away from conflict. The task is not to change human nature. The task is to create the conditions in which human nature's better angels are more likely to prevail. That is the task to which this book is addressed.

"Human nature is neither the obstacle to peace nor its guarantee. It is the canvas upon which our social, political, and cultural choices paint their consequences."

— Doctoral Research Synthesis, Kennedy University of Baptist

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Chapter Two: The Roots of War — Poverty, Injustice, and the Failure of Belonging

If we are to understand how to achieve peace, we must first understand why wars begin. Not the proximate causes — the assassination of an archduke, the invasion of a border territory, the disputed election — but the deeper, structural conditions that make war possible, even likely. I want to tell you a story.

A young man grows up in a city where unemployment among young men runs at over forty per cent. His father was never present. His school is underfunded and his teachers are overworked. The street he lives on is controlled by a gang, and joining that gang is, for many of his peers, the only available route to belonging, to income, and to a form of dignity — however distorted. The state in which he lives is ostensibly at peace: there is no declared war. But his life is saturated with violence — the violence of poverty, the violence of exclusion, the violence of being seen by his own society as disposable. Is this young man at peace? Is his society at peace?

Johan Galtung, the Norwegian peace scholar whom I regard as perhaps the most important peace theorist of the twentieth century, would say no. In his landmark 1969 essay *Violence, Peace and Peace Research*, Galtung introduced the concept of structural violence — the harm done to human beings not by direct physical force but by the organisation of society itself. A society in which a child goes hungry is a violent society, even if no one has ever struck that child. A society in which a woman is denied education because of her gender is a violent society, even if she never suffers a bruise. Structural violence kills, slowly and invisibly, and it is the most widespread form of violence on earth.

"The absence of war is not peace. Peace is the presence of justice."

— **Martin Luther King Jr.**

Poverty as a Driver of Conflict

The relationship between poverty and conflict is one of the most robust findings in the social scientific literature on war. The World Bank, the United Nations Development Programme, and a generation of academic researchers have documented it in exhaustive detail: countries with low incomes, high inequality, and limited economic opportunity are significantly more likely to experience violent conflict than countries where basic needs are met and opportunity is more evenly distributed. This is not difficult to understand at an intuitive level. Where there is nothing to lose, violence becomes more thinkable. Where basic needs go unmet, resentment accumulates. Where opportunity is monopolised by a small elite, the majority who are excluded may eventually conclude that the only way to achieve change is by force.

The economist Paul Collier's influential research into the economics of civil war, summarised in *The Bottom Billion* (2007), found that the single most reliable predictor of civil war onset was not ethnic diversity, not religious difference, not historical grievance — though all of these can be contributing factors. It was low income and slow growth. Countries trapped in poverty — what Collier called the 'conflict trap' — are caught in a vicious cycle: poverty creates the conditions for conflict, and conflict perpetuates poverty. Breaking this cycle requires external intervention — not military intervention, but economic and institutional support that enables growth to take hold and creates the material conditions in which peace becomes sustainable.

Galtung's concept of structural violence extends this analysis beyond the immediately material. Structural violence refers to the harm done by social arrangements that deny people what they need to flourish, even when no individual is wielding a weapon. The hunger of millions in a world of food abundance is structural violence. The illiteracy of children who lack access to schools is structural violence. The preventable deaths of those who cannot afford medicine is structural violence. These forms of violence kill, slowly and invisibly, and they are the most widespread forms of violence on earth. The United Nations Development Programme has long argued that sustainable peace requires sustainable development — that the two are not separate projects but aspects of a single integrated endeavour. You cannot build peace in a

landscape of mass poverty, any more than you can build a house on a foundation of sand.

The most persuasive empirical evidence for the connection between economic inequality and conflict comes from the research of scholars such as Frances Stewart, whose work on horizontal inequalities — inequalities between culturally defined groups, rather than between individuals — has demonstrated that the most dangerous form of inequality for social stability is not inequality in the abstract, but the systematic economic exclusion of identifiable communities. When one ethnic, religious, or regional group is consistently poorer, less educated, and less represented in positions of power than another, the conditions for mobilisation around group identity as a vehicle for redressing grievance are created. This is the structural dynamic that has underpinned civil conflicts from Northern Ireland to Rwanda to the Sahel region of Africa.

It bears emphasis that the relationship between poverty and conflict is not deterministic. Many poor countries do not experience civil war. Many prosperous countries do. The relationship is probabilistic: poverty increases vulnerability to conflict, particularly in combination with other risk factors. But this probabilistic finding is itself enormously important for policy. It means that investments in poverty reduction — in education, in healthcare, in economic opportunity, in the reduction of inequality between groups — are not merely humanitarian gestures. They are strategic investments in peace.

Injustice and the Need for Dignity

Alongside poverty, injustice is among the most powerful generators of conflict. By injustice, I mean not merely legal inequality — though that matters enormously — but the deeper sense of humiliation that comes from being treated as less than fully human. I have thought often about what it means to be humiliated. To have your dignity stripped from you. To be looked through rather than looked at. To be a number rather than a name, a category rather than a person. This is an experience that millions of human beings endure every day — through racism, through poverty, through the casual contempt of the powerful for the powerless.

The philosopher Martha Nussbaum has argued powerfully that the capabilities necessary for a fully human life — life itself, bodily health, bodily integrity, imagination and thought, emotional development, practical reason, affiliation with others, play, and control over one's political environment — are not luxuries. They are the minimum conditions for human dignity. A world in which these capabilities are denied to large portions of humanity is not merely unjust; it is a world that is manufacturing the conditions for conflict. Rawls's thought experiment of the veil of ignorance arrives at the same conclusion through the route of rational self-interest: behind such a veil, no rational person would choose the current international order, in which accidents of birth determine, to an overwhelming degree, the quality of life a person can expect.

The psychologist Evelin Lindner, who has spent decades studying the relationship between humiliation and conflict, argues that humiliation — the forced lowering of a person's or a group's sense of dignity and worth through violation of human rights — is perhaps the most underappreciated driver of conflict in the contemporary world. Her research across multiple conflict zones has led her to the conclusion that the experience of being humiliated generates a specific psychological response — rage, shame, and the desire for revenge or vindication — that is among the most powerful motivating forces in human behaviour. The recognition of dignity — genuine, consistent, and structural recognition, not the condescending kind — is therefore not a soft aspiration. It is a hard prerequisite for peace.

The work of the scholar Mahmood Mamdani on the African experience of colonialism and its aftershocks is illuminating here. Mamdani's analysis of the Rwandan genocide — in *When Victims Become Killers* (2001) — traces the roots of the 1994 catastrophe not simply to ancient tribal hatreds, as the popular narrative would have it, but to the specific ways in which Belgian colonial administration constructed, reified, and weaponised ethnic identities, creating a system in which Hutu and Tutsi became fixed, legally enforced categories with radically different access to power, resources, and dignity. The genocide of 1994 was not the eruption of immemorial barbarism. It was the culmination of decades of institutionalised injustice, structural humiliation, and political manipulation. Understanding this is not to excuse what

happened. It is to understand what must be prevented from happening again.

The Failure of Belonging

There is a third root cause of conflict that is less often discussed in academic literature but which my own experience has impressed upon me with great force: the failure of belonging. Human beings are social creatures. We need to belong — to a family, to a community, to a tradition, to a story that gives our lives meaning. When these structures of belonging collapse — through migration, urbanisation, economic disruption, or the dissolution of traditional communities — human beings become vulnerable to the seductions of destructive belonging: the gang, the extremist cell, the nationalist movement that offers identity at the price of hatred.

I have seen this in my own journey. I have seen young men from Nigeria, from Somalia, from Pakistan — intelligent, energetic, longing for purpose — drawn into movements that offered them brotherhood and significance at the cost of violence. And I have wondered: what would have happened if those young men had found belonging through a cricket club, a church choir, a community garden, a meaningful job? The answer, I believe, is that most of them would have been fine. The capacity for violence was not the core of who they were. It was a response to deprivation — including the deprivation of belonging.

The sociologist Robert Putnam's research into the decline of community life in the United States, summarised in *Bowling Alone* (2000), documented with remarkable comprehensiveness the consequences of declining social capital — the networks of relationship, trust, and reciprocity that enable communities to function well. Putnam found that communities with high social capital are not only more cohesive and more resilient; they are also safer, healthier, better governed, and more economically productive than communities in which social capital has been depleted. The decline of civic associations, religious communities, sports clubs, and neighbourhood networks is not a trivial social change. It is a structural transformation that leaves millions of individuals more isolated, more anxious, and more vulnerable to the appeals of movements that offer belonging through opposition to an enemy.

The doctoral research conducted at Kennedy University of Baptist confirmed this across multiple conflict contexts: the failure of belonging was a consistent background condition in radicalisation processes. Young men who had felt themselves excluded from the mainstream of their societies — economically marginalised, culturally disrespected, without meaningful community or purpose — were dramatically more vulnerable to recruitment by extremist movements than those who were embedded in functioning communities of belonging. This means that investment in community institutions — faith organisations, sports clubs, cultural associations, neighbourhood networks — is not a soft luxury. It is a hard peace imperative.

The implications extend beyond the immediate context of radicalisation. The same logic applies to the broader challenge of maintaining peaceful, cohesive societies in an era of rapid change. The forces of globalisation, digital technology, and economic transformation are simultaneously creating unprecedented prosperity for some and unprecedented dislocation for others. The communities most affected by this dislocation — the post-industrial regions of the developed world, the rural communities left behind by rapid urbanisation in the developing world — are precisely those in which the politics of grievance and exclusion find their most fertile ground. Attending to the failure of belonging is not merely a matter of social welfare. It is a matter of maintaining the conditions of peaceful democratic life.

"Where belonging is denied through legitimate means, it will be sought through illegitimate ones. Providing every human being with meaningful community is not charity. It is conflict prevention."

— Doctoral Research Finding, Kennedy University of Baptist

Chapter Three: The Danger of ‘The Other’—Identity, Fear, and Dehumanisation

There is a mechanism that lies at the heart of almost every organised programme of violence in human history, and it is worth examining carefully, because understanding it is one of the most powerful tools we have for preventing future violence. That mechanism is dehumanisation.

Before you can persuade ordinary human beings to commit extraordinary violence against other human beings, you must first persuade them that their targets are not really human — or are human in an inferior, threatening, or polluting sense. The Jews of Europe were described as rats and vermin before they were systematically murdered. The Tutsi of Rwanda were described as cockroaches before the genocide began. The enslaved Africans of the Atlantic trade were described as less than fully human by the pseudo-science of the era. This is not coincidence. It is method. Dehumanisation is the psychological technology of mass violence, and it has been perfected and deployed with terrible effectiveness across every century of recorded history.

The Psychology of In-Group and Out-Group

The social psychologist Henri Tajfel demonstrated through his famous minimal group experiments in the 1970s that human beings form in-group and out-group identities with remarkable speed and on remarkably trivial bases. Divide people arbitrarily into two groups — by the flip of a coin, by their preference for one abstract painting over another — and they will within minutes begin to favour their in-group and discriminate against the out-group. This is, it seems, a deep feature of human social cognition, with roots in the evolutionary logic of small-group survival.

But — and this is crucial — Tajfel also demonstrated that the intensity of inter-group hostility is not fixed. It varies enormously depending on conditions. Gordon Allport’s landmark study *The*

Nature of Prejudice (1954) generated what has become known as Contact Theory: the finding that meaningful contact between members of different groups, under conditions of equal status, common goals, cooperative interdependence, and institutional support, consistently reduces prejudice and inter-group hostility. This finding has been replicated in hundreds of subsequent studies across dozens of contexts. It tells us something profoundly important: we can construct 'the other', and we can also deconstruct 'the other'. The barriers that make violence possible are human constructions, and what is constructed can be dismantled.

The Israeli social psychologist Daniel Bar-Tal has devoted his career to studying what he calls 'intractable conflicts' — conflicts characterised by their longevity, their intensity, their apparent imperviousness to resolution, and the degree to which they become embedded in the collective psychology of the societies involved. His research has documented the formation of what he calls 'conflict-supporting societal beliefs': narratives that depict one's own group as just and victimised and the other group as threatening and immoral. These beliefs, once formed, are extraordinarily resistant to contrary evidence. They are transmitted from generation to generation through education systems, media, and cultural life. And they create the psychological landscape within which violence becomes thinkable, even righteous. Understanding how these beliefs form and persist is essential to understanding how peace processes succeed or fail.

The neuroscience of inter-group conflict adds another dimension to this picture. Research using neuroimaging has demonstrated that the mere perception of out-group members activates brain regions associated with disgust and fear — the same regions activated by the perception of morally repugnant objects or dangerous threats. This dehumanising response can be activated rapidly, even automatically, and can override more considered moral reasoning. But the same research has also demonstrated that this response is modifiable: exposure to counter-stereotypic information about out-group members, cultivation of perspective-taking, and the development of what psychologists call 'common identity' — the recognition that self and other both belong to a larger shared category — can all reduce the automatic dehumanising response.

The neuroscience of prejudice is, therefore, not a counsel of despair. It is a research agenda for peace education.

The Construction of 'The Other'

The social psychologist Henri Tajfel demonstrated through his famous minimal group experiments in the 1970s that human beings form in-group and out-group identities with remarkable speed and on remarkably trivial bases. The philosopher Kwame Anthony Appiah, in *The Ethics of Identity* (2005), has explored how identity — the stories people tell about who they are and to which groups they belong — is always a construction, never simply a discovery. Identities are not facts about the world. They are interpretive frameworks through which human beings make sense of their experience, organise their loyalties, and determine the boundaries of their moral concern. This insight has profound implications for peacebuilding: if identities are constructed, they can also be reconstructed. The stories that divide us are not fixed. They can be told differently.

The political scientist Benedict Anderson called nations ‘imagined communities’ — and the imagination that constructs communities can also, when turned to darker purposes, construct enemies. What Anderson’s analysis makes clear is that the national, ethnic, and religious identities that are most commonly invoked to justify violence are not primordial facts about human beings. They are historically produced, culturally maintained, and politically manipulable constructions. This does not mean they are not real — they are intensely real in their consequences. But it does mean that they are not inevitable. The communities we imagine can be imagined differently.

The Role of Narrative in Manufacturing Division

Dehumanisation does not happen in a vacuum. It requires a narrative — a story about who ‘they’ are and why ‘they’ are dangerous. These narratives are constructed and propagated, often deliberately, by leaders who benefit from the mobilisation of group hostility. The historian Christopher Browning’s detailed study of Reserve Police Battalion 101, in *Ordinary Men* (1992), documented how a group of middle-aged German policemen were

gradually transformed, through a combination of ideological indoctrination, peer pressure, and incremental habituation to violence, into perpetrators of mass murder. The transformation did not happen overnight. It happened through a narrative process: a gradually intensifying story about the identity and the dangerousness of the victims, combined with a gradually expanding definition of what constituted legitimate action.

In the age of social media and algorithmically curated information, the industrial production of dehumanising narratives has become cheaper, faster, and more scalable than at any previous point in history. A single tweet, a single viral video, a single algorithmically amplified post, can reach millions of people within hours. The psychological mechanisms of tribal identity and inter-group hostility that evolved in the context of small face-to-face communities are now being activated at global scale, with consequences that the architects of these platforms have consistently refused to fully acknowledge or address.

The genocide in Myanmar in 2017 was preceded and accompanied by a campaign of hatred on Facebook. The January 2021 assault on the United States Capitol was organised on social media platforms. The connection between digital dehumanisation and physical violence is no longer theoretical. It is documented. And it demands a response that is simultaneously technological — the redesign of platforms to reduce the amplification of divisive content — and cultural — the cultivation, through education and public life, of the habits of mind and heart that resist dehumanisation.

The researcher Kate Starbird at the University of Washington has documented in detail the architecture of online disinformation — the networks through which false and divisive narratives are created, amplified, and made to appear organic. Her findings confirm what common sense might suggest: that much of the dehumanising content that appears to spread spontaneously through social networks is in fact deliberately seeded and amplified, often by state actors or politically motivated organisations with a direct interest in social division. Understanding this is not cause for paralysis. It is cause for vigilance — and for the development of the critical media literacy that is one of the most important gifts that education can provide.

The Antidote: Humanisation and Encounter

The antidote to dehumanisation is, of course, humanisation — and humanisation happens through encounter, through story, through education, and through the cultivation of what the philosopher Emmanuel Levinas called ‘the face of the other’: the capacity to see, in the stranger, not a threat or a category, but a person — a person with a mother, with memories, with fear, with longing, with a story as complex and as precious as your own.

I have experienced this antidote at work, many times. I have sat with people who, by the logic of sectarian division, should have been my enemies, and I have discovered in them not enemies but human beings. I have broken bread with people of different faiths, different races, different politics, and found that the humanity we share is infinitely more substantial than the differences that divide us. This is not sentimentality. It is one of the most reliable findings in social psychology: meaningful personal encounter across group lines is among the most effective interventions for reducing prejudice and hostility that human beings have yet discovered.

The philosopher Richard Rorty argued, in *Contingency, Irony, and Solidarity* (1989), that the expansion of the circle of moral concern — the gradual extension of our sense of ‘us’ to include those who previously seemed like ‘them’ — happens less through abstract philosophical argument than through the arts, literature, and the specific, vivid, particular stories of individual human lives. When we read a novel that allows us to inhabit the interior experience of someone from a different culture, or watch a film that shows us the humanity of someone we might otherwise have dismissed as an enemy, something happens to us. Our circle of concern expands. Our capacity for violence — which requires the dehumanisation of its objects — contracts. This is the peace argument for the arts, for literature, for the cultivation of empathetic imagination in education: it is not a luxury. It is a survival strategy for the species.

The Seeds of Peace programme, founded in 1993 by journalist John Wallach, has brought together teenagers from regions of conflict — Israel and Palestine, India and Pakistan, Greece and Turkey — for intensive programmes of dialogue and shared activity. The evidence of its effectiveness is documented in careful follow-up research: participants consistently show greater empathy for the

other group, greater capacity for critical thinking about conflict narratives, and greater commitment to peaceful engagement than their non-participant peers. This evidence is important not because it suggests that a summer camp can resolve the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, but because it demonstrates the principle: that encounter, under the right conditions, humanises. And humanisation is the foundation of peace.

"When we learn to see the face of the other — not the category, not the threat, not the enemy, but the person — the architecture of violence begins to crumble."

— Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu, PhD,
Kennedy University of Baptist

Chapter Four:

The Contemporary World and Its Interlocking Challenges

The world that any serious peacebuilder must confront is shaped by a set of overlapping and mutually reinforcing challenges that have no clear precedent in human history. The doctoral research conducted at Kennedy University of Baptist identified five principal clusters of contemporary threat to global peace. Each is significant in its own right. Together, they constitute a system of interconnected dangers that demands a correspondingly integrated response.

Armed Conflict in Transformation

The character of armed conflict has changed dramatically since 1945. Inter-state wars — direct military confrontations between national armies — have become rarer, though not extinct. Russia's invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, the most consequential inter-state war in Europe since 1945, demonstrated with terrible clarity that this form of conflict has not been consigned to history. It demonstrated also something that peace scholars had long understood but that policymakers had sometimes forgotten: that the territorial ambitions and the revisionist nationalism of the mid-twentieth century can resurface even in nominally post-Cold War conditions, whenever the institutional checks against aggression are sufficiently weakened.

The dominant form of armed violence today, however, is intra-state conflict: civil wars, insurgencies, proxy conflicts, and low-intensity violence that can persist for decades. Yemen, Sudan, the Democratic Republic of Congo, Myanmar, and the Sahel region of Africa are among the most devastating current examples. These conflicts share a number of structural features: they are often fuelled by competition over natural resources, exacerbated by the availability of cheap small arms, sustained by the involvement of external actors pursuing their own interests, and perpetuated by the

collapse of state institutions that might otherwise channel grievances into non-violent political processes.

The United Nations estimates that more than one hundred million people were forcibly displaced from their homes by conflict and persecution in 2022 — a figure unprecedented in modern history. This displacement is not merely a humanitarian catastrophe in itself. It is a driver of further instability, as the social, political, and economic pressures of large-scale migration generate new tensions in receiving communities and provide fertile ground for the politics of fear and exclusion. The management of displacement is therefore not only a humanitarian imperative but a peace imperative.

The proliferation of non-state armed actors — paramilitaries, militias, terrorist organisations, criminal gangs with quasi-political functions — has complicated enormously the landscape of conflict management. Traditional diplomacy, designed for negotiation between state actors, is ill-suited to engaging with the fractured, ideologically heterogeneous, often deliberately leaderless structures of contemporary non-state violence. New forms of engagement — community-based peacebuilding, dialogue with armed groups, the development of alternative economic opportunities for combatants — are essential components of any realistic peace strategy in these contexts.

Terrorism and the Roots of Radicalisation

Terrorism — the deliberate targeting of civilians for political ends — represents a specific and particularly destabilising form of violence. Research consistently identifies political exclusion, economic marginalisation, perceived humiliation, and the failure of belonging as key drivers of the radicalisation processes that lead individuals into terrorist violence. Effective counter-terrorism therefore requires not only security measures but the sustained work of addressing these root causes.

The United Kingdom's own experience with domestic terrorism — from the IRA's mainland campaign to the Islamist-inspired attacks of the 2000s and 2010s — provides a rich and painful body of evidence for this conclusion. The communities most vulnerable to radicalisation have consistently been those experiencing the

greatest combination of economic deprivation, social marginalisation, and perceived cultural disrespect. The Prevent programme, whatever its limitations and controversies, was founded on the correct insight that counter-terrorism requires community engagement and the addressing of grievance, not only surveillance and arrest.

The phenomenon of online radicalisation has added a new dimension to these challenges that the policy apparatus has been slow to address. The architecture of social media platforms, which amplifies emotionally activating content and creates enclosed information environments, has proved extraordinarily effective at accelerating radicalisation processes that might previously have taken years and required physical proximity to extremist networks. Young people in isolated communities, or experiencing acute personal crises, can within months be drawn into ideological frameworks that legitimise violence, through interactions that occur entirely online and that leave few traces for traditional counter-terrorism monitoring to detect.

The response to terrorism that focuses primarily on security measures — surveillance, detention, military action — without addressing the structural conditions that generate radicalisation, is not only incomplete; it is, in many cases, counter-productive. Military action that results in civilian casualties, or security programmes that treat entire communities as suspect, can generate precisely the sense of humiliation, exclusion, and grievance that drives radicalisation. This is not an argument against security measures. It is an argument for recognising that security measures alone cannot solve a problem with deep social roots.

Climate Change as a Threat Multiplier

Climate change is recognised by defence ministries, intelligence agencies, and peace scholars alike as one of the most significant structural threats to global security in the twenty-first century. The UN Security Council has formally recognised it as a threat multiplier: a force that intensifies existing vulnerabilities and amplifies existing conflicts. Rising temperatures and changing rainfall patterns are reducing agricultural yields in already food-insecure regions. Extreme weather events are displacing populations. Sea-level rise threatens entire low-lying territories.

The connections between climate change and conflict are not abstract. In the Sahel region of Africa — the semi-arid belt stretching from Senegal in the west to Sudan and Ethiopia in the east — the combination of population growth, declining agricultural productivity, and expanding desertification has intensified competition between farmers and herders, fuelled inter-communal violence, and provided the context within which extremist movements have found new recruits. In Syria, the worst drought in recorded history between 2006 and 2010 drove an estimated 1.5 million people from their agricultural livelihoods into already overcrowded cities, contributing to the social tensions that preceded the 2011 uprising. The relationship is complex and multi-causal, and it would be reductive to describe the Syrian civil war as a ‘climate war’. But climate stress was a significant contributing factor to the conditions from which conflict emerged.

The doctoral research found that the communities most vulnerable to climate-driven conflict are almost without exception also the communities least responsible for global emissions. This is not merely an environmental injustice. It is a peace injustice, and it demands a peace response. The wealthy nations that have contributed most to the accumulation of greenhouse gases in the atmosphere have an obligation — grounded in both justice and in long-term self-interest — to take the lead in reducing emissions and in supporting the adaptation of the most vulnerable communities. Climate finance and climate adaptation are, in this sense, components of a peace agenda.

The implications for the longer term are even more sobering. The scenarios developed by climate scientists for mid-century and beyond — involving potentially hundreds of millions of climate-displaced people, dramatic reductions in agricultural yields in tropical and sub-tropical regions, and increasing frequency and severity of extreme weather events — represent a scale of potential instability that dwarfs anything the current international security architecture was designed to manage. Addressing climate change is therefore not merely an environmental imperative. It is, in the most fundamental sense, a peace imperative.

Technological Disruption and Digital Disinformation

The digital revolution has transformed the landscape of both conflict and peacebuilding. Social media platforms, optimised for engagement rather than truth, are structurally better at propagating content that provokes outrage and fear than content that informs and promotes understanding. The researcher Soroush Vosoughi and colleagues at MIT demonstrated in a 2018 study published in *Science* that false news spreads faster, reaches more people, and penetrates further into social networks than true news — and that this differential spread is driven not by bots but by human users, who find novel and emotionally activating content more shareable regardless of its accuracy.

The consequences for peacebuilding are significant and documented. The erosion of shared factual reference points — the creation of what scholars have called ‘epistemic communities’ in which different groups inhabit fundamentally different informational worlds — makes the kind of dialogue and negotiation on which peaceful conflict resolution depends significantly harder. If the parties to a conflict do not share basic facts about what has happened and what is happening, the construction of a common narrative and a shared future becomes extraordinarily difficult.

At the same time, technology offers new and significant tools for peacebuilding: early warning systems powered by artificial intelligence, digital platforms connecting peacebuilders across borders, satellite documentation of human rights violations. The Ushahidi platform, developed after the post-election violence in Kenya in 2007, pioneered the use of crowdsourced digital mapping to document conflict events in real time, enabling both early warning and accountability. WITNESS, the human rights organisation, has developed protocols for the use of mobile phone video as legal evidence of human rights violations, enabling a form of accountability that was simply impossible before the smartphone era. The question for our moment is whether democratic governance structures can develop quickly enough to maximise these peace-positive possibilities while containing the conflict-accelerating ones.

Democratic Erosion and the Peace Connection

The most authoritative annual surveys of political freedom record a consistent downward trend in democratic indicators across the world since approximately 2006. Freedom House, the Economist Intelligence Unit, and the Varieties of Democracy project at the University of Gothenburg all document the same troubling pattern: more countries are experiencing significant democratic backsliding than are making democratic progress. This is occurring across every region of the world — in Latin America, in sub-Saharan Africa, in South and East Asia, and, with unprecedented explicitness, within the established democracies of Europe and North America.

This matters directly for peace. Democracies rarely go to war with one another — the Democratic Peace theory is one of the most replicated findings in political science. This finding, first documented systematically by Michael Doyle in the 1980s, has generated enormous research attention and some significant theoretical dispute about its mechanisms. But its empirical robustness is hard to deny: the historical record contains no clear examples of wars between established liberal democracies. If democratic erosion continues, the conditions that have sustained the long peace between major powers since 1945 will be undermined.

Democracies are also better able to manage internal conflicts through non-violent institutional mechanisms. The availability of free elections, independent courts, a free press, and civil society organisations — the institutional architecture of democratic governance — provides legitimate channels through which political grievances can be expressed and, at least partially, addressed. When these channels are closed or corrupted, the pressure that might otherwise find expression through the ballot box or the editorial column seeks other outlets. The erosion of democratic institutions is therefore not merely a political problem. It is a peace emergency. And it demands a peace response: sustained investment in the institutions of democratic governance, in the independent media and civil society that hold power to account, and in the civic education that enables citizens to participate effectively in democratic life.

The doctoral research at Kennedy University of Baptist identified a striking pattern across multiple country case studies: the deterioration of democratic institutions consistently preceded by several years the outbreak or intensification of violent conflict. The sequence was not random. It was structural: as democratic accountability eroded, the elites who benefited from that erosion used the resulting impunity to pursue policies of exclusion and enrichment that generated the grievances from which conflict subsequently emerged. This finding has a clear policy implication: the defence of democratic institutions is not merely a matter of political principle. It is a foundational investment in peace.

"The five contemporary challenges are not separate problems. They constitute a single interconnected system. They demand a single integrated response."

— Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu, PhD,
Kennedy University of Baptist

NEXUS STORIES PUBLICATION®

PART TWO

The Great Traditions of Peace

What Thinkers, Faiths, and Artists Have Taught Us

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Chapter Five:

Philosophers of Peace — From Kant to Ubuntu

When I was a young man in Nigeria, I was told that philosophy was a luxury — something for the comfortable and the idle. The poor, I was told, did not have time for philosophy; they had time only for survival. I have spent a great part of my adult life disagreeing with that view. Philosophy — serious, rigorous, sustained thought about how we ought to live and how society ought to be organised — is not a luxury. It is a necessity. Without it, we stumble forward driven by habit and impulse and the self-interest of the powerful. With it, we have at least the possibility of seeing where we are going and choosing a better direction.

The philosophical traditions of humanity have, over millennia, generated a remarkable body of thought about peace, justice, and the conditions for human flourishing. In this chapter, I want to explore several of the most important contributions — not as a survey of intellectual history, but as a resource for the practical work of building peace. These are not merely theories. They are tools.

Immanuel Kant: Perpetual Peace and the Institutional Vision

In 1795, the German philosopher Immanuel Kant published one of the most influential essays in the history of political thought: *Perpetual Peace: A Philosophical Sketch*. Kant argued — against the fatalists of his day, as against the fatalists of ours — that perpetual peace between nations was not merely desirable but achievable, and he set out the conditions required to achieve it. These conditions included: that all states adopt republican constitutions, with separation of powers and representative governance; that a federation of free states be established to provide a framework for resolving disputes without war; and that universal hospitality — the right of every human being to be received peaceably by any state — be recognised as a principle of international law.

The prescience of Kant's vision is extraordinary. The United Nations is recognisably an attempt to realise the federation of states he envisaged. The Universal Declaration of Human Rights is recognisably an attempt to codify the universal hospitality he advocated. The institutions of international law — the International Court of Justice, the International Criminal Court, the Geneva Conventions — are recognisably the institutional architecture he proposed. Kant's insight — that peace requires not only goodwill but institutional architecture, that the gradual construction of frameworks within which cooperation is more rational and more rewarding than conflict is one of the most reliable pathways to durable peace — remains essential and urgently relevant.

What is often less emphasised in accounts of Kant's political philosophy is the moral depth of his argument. For Kant, the case for perpetual peace was not merely a matter of practical self-interest — though he believed rational self-interest supported it. It was a moral imperative, grounded in his categorical imperative: the foundational principle that we must act only according to maxims that we could will to be universal laws. A world of perpetual war is a world in which violence is universalised. A world of perpetual peace is a world in which the universal law respects the dignity of every rational being. The pursuit of peace is therefore, for Kant, not an optional aspiration but a categorical moral requirement.

Kant's work has been criticised, by realist scholars of international relations, for its apparent utopianism — its failure to adequately reckon with the power politics of the real world of states. This criticism has some force. But Kant was not naive about power. He understood that powerful states would resist the constraints of international law whenever they calculated that the costs of compliance exceeded the benefits. His response to this problem was institutional: the federation of free states was designed not to eliminate power politics, but to change its context, by making the long-term costs of aggression higher than the long-term benefits of cooperative governance. This is, as I shall argue in the chapters on the United Nations and on economic integration, exactly the right logic for contemporary peacebuilding.

John Stuart Mill: Liberty, Diversity, and the Ethics of Intervention

The British philosopher John Stuart Mill grappled with questions that remain agonisingly relevant: the defence of individual liberty and intellectual diversity, and the thorny question of when, if ever, it is permissible for one state to intervene in the affairs of another. In *On Liberty* (1859), Mill argued that freedom of thought and expression are not merely personal rights but social necessities — that the collision of different ideas is the condition for the emergence of truth and the prevention of the intellectual stagnation that breeds dogmatism and, eventually, violence. His argument is as relevant in the age of social media algorithms as it was in the era of Victorian publishing: closed information environments, in which people are exposed only to views that confirm their existing beliefs, produce not wisdom but the hardening of prejudice.

Mill's answer to the intervention question — that genuine political freedom must be won by a people themselves, but that extreme oppression may justify intervention — continues to shape the most difficult debates in international ethics. The humanitarian intervention debate of the 1990s — in Bosnia, in Kosovo, in Rwanda where intervention came too late — was in many ways a debate conducted in Mill's terms. The responsibility to protect, adopted by the United Nations General Assembly in 2005, represents the contemporary international community's attempt to resolve the tension that Mill identified: between the sovereignty of states and the rights of individuals within those states. It has not resolved the tension. But it has moved the conversation.

Mill's utilitarianism — the principle that the right action is the one that produces the greatest happiness for the greatest number — provides one important framework for thinking about the obligations of wealthy nations towards the global poor. If the marginal utility of a dollar is vastly higher for a person living in extreme poverty than for a person living in comfort, then the allocation of global resources that exists under the current international order is, on utilitarian grounds, extraordinarily inefficient as well as unjust. This is a conclusion that has been developed with great rigour by the philosopher Peter Singer in his influential arguments for global redistribution, and that has

generated important practical initiatives, including the effective altruism movement.

John Rawls: Justice as Fairness and Global Obligations

The most influential political philosopher of the twentieth century, the American John Rawls, approached the question of peace from the direction of justice. In *A Theory of Justice* (1971), his thought experiment of the veil of ignorance asked: what principles of social organisation would rational individuals choose if they did not know what position in society they would occupy? His Difference Principle — that inequalities are only acceptable insofar as they benefit the least advantaged members of society — generates, when applied globally, powerful obligations on wealthy nations to attend to the conditions of those who suffer poverty, exclusion, and violence.

Rawls himself, in his later work *The Law of Peoples* (1999), drew back from the full global application of his theory of justice — a decision that his critics, including Thomas Pogge and Kok-Chor Tan, have argued was inconsistent and insufficiently attentive to the ways in which the existing international order reflects and perpetuates the injustices of colonialism and unequal economic power. Pogge's work, in particular, has made a powerful case that wealthy nations are not merely failing to help the global poor; through their support of unjust international institutions, their willingness to do business with corrupt elites, and their maintenance of intellectual property regimes that prevent the diffusion of life-saving technologies, they are actively harming them. If Pogge is right — and the evidence he marshals is substantial — the obligations of the wealthy world go beyond charity. They include the reform of the structures through which harm is being done.

The Rawlsian framework has been particularly influential in the development of what philosophers call 'global justice theory' — the attempt to develop principles of justice that apply not only within states but between them. Behind the veil of ignorance, not knowing whether one would be born in London or in South Sudan, no rational agent would choose the current international order. This thought experiment has generated a substantial body of

philosophical argument for the reform of international economic institutions, the restructuring of trade and intellectual property regimes, and the more equitable distribution of the benefits of globalisation. This is not merely academic philosophy. It is the intellectual foundation of the most serious contemporary arguments for the reform of global governance.

Ubuntu: The African Philosophy of Relational Peace

It would be remiss, in a book written by a man of African heritage, not to engage with the great peace tradition of African philosophy — and in particular with the concept of Ubuntu. Ubuntu, a term from the Zulu and Xhosa languages, is most commonly translated as ‘I am because we are’. It expresses a fundamentally relational understanding of human identity: the idea that the self does not exist in isolation, but is constituted through relationships with others. My wellbeing is bound up with your wellbeing. My humanity is expressed through my recognition of your humanity. When you suffer, I am diminished.

This is, in some respects, a very different starting point from the liberal Western tradition, which tends to begin with the individual and work outwards towards community. Ubuntu begins with community and works inwards towards the self. The individual, in this tradition, is not a pre-social atom whose relationships with others are external and optional; the individual is constituted by relationships, brought into being by community, and sustained by the network of mutual recognition and care that community provides. To be human, in the Ubuntu tradition, is to be in relationship.

Nelson Mandela, perhaps the greatest living embodiment of Ubuntu in the political sphere, demonstrated its practical force in one of the most remarkable political careers of the twentieth century. After twenty-seven years of unjust imprisonment, he emerged not with vengeance but with the extraordinary capacity for reconciliation. His willingness to negotiate with his former oppressors, to serve alongside them in a government of national unity, to speak of a rainbow nation rather than a black nation — these were not the expressions of naivety. They were the expressions of a philosophy that understood human flourishing as fundamentally collective, and that recognised that the project of

building a free South Africa required the inclusion rather than the exclusion of every South African.

The Truth and Reconciliation Commission of South Africa, chaired by Archbishop Desmond Tutu and guided by Ubuntu principles, represented one of the most ambitious and, ultimately, most studied experiments in transitional justice that the modern world has produced. Its approach — granting amnesty in exchange for full public disclosure, prioritising the restoration of the dignity of victims over punitive justice, creating a public record of what had happened rather than allowing it to be buried — was controversial and remains disputed. It did not achieve full justice for all victims. But it produced something extraordinary: a public acknowledgement of the truth of apartheid's crimes, a framework for national reconciliation that allowed a deeply divided society to function democratically, and a model that has influenced transitional justice processes from Sierra Leone to Colombia to Rwanda.

Ubuntu philosophy has much to offer contemporary global ethics. Its insistence on the relational constitution of the self — the recognition that my flourishing is bound up with yours, that a world in which others suffer is a world in which I am diminished — provides a powerful philosophical grounding for the obligations of global solidarity that justice demands. Its emphasis on community and relationship as the preconditions of human dignity provides a corrective to forms of individualism that atomise people and strip away the communal structures that make human flourishing possible. And its demonstrated capacity — in the South African transition — to provide a practical framework for reconciliation after devastating violence offers a model that is as relevant today as it was in the 1990s.

"The philosophical traditions of humanity, East and West, North and South, converge on a single insight: that durable peace is inseparable from justice, from dignity, and from the recognition of our fundamental interdependence."

— Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu, PhD,
Kennedy University of Baptist

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— End of Elaborated Section —

World Peace: Global Peace Is Possible

Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu

Kennedy University of Baptist, United States of America

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Chapter Six:

Religious Traditions and the Call to Peace

I approach this chapter with particular care and particular passion, because it touches on the most intimate dimensions of my own journey. I was raised in a Muslim household. I later became a Christian. I have therefore experienced from the inside both of the world's two largest religious traditions — and I can testify that, properly understood, both of them are profoundly committed to peace. The violence done in the name of religion is, I believe, a betrayal of religion — a distortion of traditions that, at their core, preach compassion, justice, and the sacredness of human life.

This is not a comfortable statement in the contemporary world, where religious violence is a daily fact and where it is tempting, for both believers and secular critics, to conclude either that religion is inherently violent or that the violence done in religion's name is somehow not authentically religious. I want to resist both conclusions. Religious traditions are human phenomena: they contain, within themselves, both the resources for violence and the resources for peace. The question is which resources are drawn upon, in which contexts, and by whom. The answer to that question is not determined by theology alone. It is shaped by political context, by the economic interests of religious institutions, by the social dynamics of in-group and out-group identity, and by the specific interpretive choices of religious leaders and communities. Understanding this is the beginning of using religion's peace resources more effectively and containing its violence-enabling resources more firmly.

Islam: Salaam and the Ethics of Justice

The word Islam is derived from the same Arabic root as salaam — peace. This is not merely an etymological coincidence. It reflects a theological conviction at the heart of the Islamic tradition: that submission to God — which is the meaning of Islam — is itself an act of peace, a bringing of the self into alignment with the divine will, which is a will for justice, compassion, and the flourishing of all human beings. The traditional Muslim greeting, As-salamu alaykum, means Peace be upon you. The Quran describes the

divine as Al-Salam — the Peace. Islam proclaims that God calls human beings to the abode of peace.

The Islamic tradition has a rich and sophisticated engagement with questions of peace and justice. The concept of jihad — so often misunderstood and misrepresented in Western discourse — refers primarily not to armed conflict but to the inner struggle of the believer to live in accordance with God's will. The greater jihad, as the Prophet Muhammad reportedly said, is the struggle against the self: against selfishness, against pride, against the temptation to treat others unjustly. The conditions for justified warfare in Islamic jurisprudence are highly restrictive: war is permitted only in defence, only when all peaceful alternatives have been exhausted, and only under the authority of legitimate leadership. The rules of conduct in war, as developed by classical Islamic scholars such as al-Shaybani in the eighth century, include prohibitions on targeting non-combatants, destroying crops and infrastructure, and mistreating prisoners — prohibitions that are consonant with, and in some cases predate, the most demanding standards of modern international humanitarian law.

The tradition of Islamic peacebuilding is ancient and deep. The Prophet Muhammad's Constitution of Medina, established in the seventh century, created a pluralistic political community in which Muslims, Jews, and polytheists lived together under common civic obligations while maintaining their distinct religious identities. The concept of *dhimma* — protected status for non-Muslim communities under Islamic governance — reflected a recognition, however imperfect in its historical application, that religious diversity requires legal protection. The great civilisational achievements of Islamic culture during its classical period — in philosophy, mathematics, medicine, architecture, and the arts — were achievements made possible by exactly this kind of pluralistic, peace-enabling social order.

For a man who began his own spiritual journey within Islam, these insights are not abstract. They are lived. The practice of *salat* — the five daily prayers — is itself a practice of peace: a regular, structured interruption of the demands of the world, a reorientation of attention towards the sacred and the communal. The generosity of *zakat* — the obligation of almsgiving, one of the five pillars of the faith — is a structural commitment to the wellbeing of the

community: a recognition that the surplus of the wealthy creates obligations towards the poor. The solidarity of Ramadan, in which shared fasting creates shared experience across all social divides, is a yearly practice of the equality that peace requires. These are not peripheral features of Islam. They are its core. They are the resources from which an Islamic peacebuilding has been built, and from which it can be built again.

The contemporary world needs a recovery of this Islamic peace tradition — not as a counter-narrative to extremism, though it is urgently needed for that purpose, but as a positive contribution to the global project of building a more peaceful world. Islamic scholars and religious leaders have an irreplaceable role to play in this recovery: in teaching the texts, in modelling the practices, and in demonstrating, through the quality of their own communities, what an Islam at peace with the world looks like.

Christianity: Shalom and the Way of Nonviolence

In the Hebrew Bible, from which Christian tradition draws so deeply, the word for peace is shalom — a term that encompasses far more than the mere absence of conflict. Shalom means wholeness, completeness, harmony, the flourishing of all creation. It is the condition of the world as God intends it: a world in which every human being has enough, every relationship is just, every creature inhabits its proper place in the web of creation. The prophets of Israel proclaimed shalom as both a divine promise and a human obligation: the obligation to build, in the present world, the conditions of justice and right relationship that shalom requires.

The New Testament carries forward and radicalises this vision. Jesus of Nazareth proclaimed in the Sermon on the Mount: Blessed are the peacemakers, for they shall be called children of God. He commanded his followers to love their enemies, to pray for those who persecute them, to turn the other cheek. These injunctions have often been domesticated into mere personal ethics, stripped of their radical social and political implications. But they are, in their original context, revolutionary. In a world organised by the logic of retaliation and honour, Jesus proclaimed the logic of grace and reconciliation. The Kingdom of God he announced was not merely a spiritual realm but a new social order: one in which the

poor are blessed, the meek inherit the earth, and the violent are not those who prevail.

Martin Luther King Jr.'s theology of nonviolent resistance explicitly grounded political activism in this Christian conviction. His argument was not merely that nonviolence was tactically superior to violence — though he believed it was, and the historical record of the American civil rights movement provides substantial evidence for that belief. His deeper argument was that violence betrays the fundamental truth about human nature: that every human being, oppressor and oppressed alike, carries the image of God, and that the goal of the struggle for justice must be the redemption of both oppressor and oppressed into a new relationship of mutual recognition and respect. King called this the Beloved Community: not a world in which the oppressors are overthrown and the oppressed take power, but a world in which the distinction between oppressor and oppressed is itself overcome through the transformative power of redemptive suffering and love.

The history of Christianity contains both its peace tradition and its violence tradition. The Crusades, the religious wars of the Reformation era, the use of Christian identity to justify slavery and colonialism — these are real parts of the Christian story and must not be minimised. But they exist alongside the tradition of the Quakers, who refused to bear arms from their founding in the seventeenth century and whose testimony of peace has made them among the most effective practitioners of conflict mediation in the modern world. They exist alongside the tradition of Dietrich Bonhoeffer, who gave his life in resistance to Nazism. They exist alongside the tradition of Oscar Romero, who was murdered in El Salvador for speaking truth to power. They exist alongside the tradition of the Catholic Worker movement, the Christian Peacemaker Teams, the countless ordinary congregations in conflict zones that have maintained spaces of sanctuary and reconciliation through the darkest of circumstances. The peace tradition of Christianity is not a marginal footnote. It is the tradition of the cross itself: the conviction that violence is overcome not by greater violence but by the willingness to absorb its cost and still respond with love.

Other Traditions and the Cross-Traditional Convergence

The commitment to peace is not the exclusive property of Christianity and Islam. Buddhism teaches ahimsa — non-harm — as a foundational ethical principle, expressed in the five precepts that govern lay Buddhist life and in the more demanding commitments of the monastic orders. The Buddhist concept of metta — loving-kindness, the cultivation of goodwill towards all beings without exception — is a spiritual practice with profoundly practical social implications. When the Fourteenth Dalai Lama advocates for a secular ethics grounded in universal compassion, he is drawing on the deepest resources of a tradition that has been practising the cultivation of peace as a spiritual discipline for two and a half millennia.

Mahatma Gandhi, drawing on the Hindu concept of ahimsa alongside the inspiration of Tolstoy and Thoreau, developed the philosophy and practice of satyagraha — truth-force or soul-force — that would defeat the British Empire in India through a combination of non-violent resistance, moral witness, and the systematic exposure of imperial violence to the conscience of the world. Gandhi's achievement was not merely political. It was philosophical: he demonstrated, through practice, that non-violence is not passivity but an extraordinarily demanding form of moral courage, and that it is, under the right conditions, a more powerful political tool than violence.

The Jewish tradition's concept of tikkun olam — the repair of the world — calls every Jew to active engagement with the work of justice and healing. The Talmudic teaching that to save a single life is to save an entire world, and to destroy a single life is to destroy an entire world, grounds an ethics of the particular and the irreplaceable that is at the heart of a Jewish approach to peacebuilding. The Jewish concept of tzedek — justice, righteousness — which is not charity but obligation, not optional giving but the fulfilment of a moral requirement, provides a robust theological foundation for the structural justice that peace requires.

The doctoral research at Kennedy University of Baptist found robust convergence across six major traditions — Christianity, Islam, Hinduism, Buddhism, Judaism, and indigenous spiritual traditions — on a core set of values: the fundamental dignity of

every human being, the imperative of compassion, the requirement of justice as a precondition of peace, and the illegitimacy of gratuitous violence. This convergence is not superficial. It runs deep into the theological and philosophical heart of each tradition. And it provides a remarkable resource for peacebuilders: in a world where religious difference is so often weaponised as a justification for conflict, the evidence that the deepest commitments of the world's major traditions actually converge on peace is a powerful and underutilised counter-narrative.

The practical implication is significant: interfaith dialogue, properly conducted, is not merely an exercise in mutual tolerance. It is a joint retrieval of shared resources for peacebuilding. When religious leaders of different traditions sit together, not to manage their differences but to explore their shared commitments, they discover that they have more to work with than they might have imagined. And the communities they lead, seeing their leaders in genuine dialogue, receive a powerful signal that difference and division are not the same thing.

“Religious communities, when they engage honestly with their own traditions, are among the most powerful forces for reconciliation available to humanity.”

— **Doctoral Research Finding, Kennedy University of Baptist**

Chapter Seven:

The Literature of Peace — From Tolstoy to the Present Day

Literature is not merely entertainment. At its best, it is one of the most powerful instruments of human moral development that exists — the means by which we imaginatively inhabit other lives, extend our sympathy across barriers of culture and experience, and develop the empathetic understanding that is one of the foundations of peace. The philosopher and legal scholar Martha Nussbaum has argued across several major works — *Poetic Justice* (1995), *Cultivating Humanity* (1997), and *Not for Profit* (2010) — that literature plays an essential role in the formation of what she calls the narrative imagination: the capacity to understand the story of another person's life from the inside. Without this capacity, she argues, democratic citizenship degenerates into a competition of interests in which those who lack political power are simply invisible to those who possess it.

Empirical research confirms Nussbaum's philosophical argument. Reading literary fiction correlates with increased empathic capacity, with improvements in what psychologists call theory of mind — the ability to understand and imaginatively inhabit the mental states of others. The psychologists David Comer Kidd and Emanuele Castano, in research published in *Science* in 2013, demonstrated experimentally that reading literary fiction — as distinct from popular genre fiction or non-fiction — improved scores on tests of social cognition. The mechanism they proposed is that literary fiction, by presenting psychologically complex, morally ambiguous characters whose inner lives are not fully explained, exercises the same cognitive muscles that are required for navigating the complexity of real human relationships. This is a finding of direct relevance to peace education: if literature builds the psychological capacities on which peaceful social life depends, then the teaching of literature is not a luxury in the school curriculum. It is a peace investment.

Leo Tolstoy: War, Peace, and the Moral Vision

It would be impossible to write a book with my title without engaging with Leo Tolstoy's *War and Peace*, the greatest novel ever written on these themes. Tolstoy's extraordinary panorama of Russian life during the Napoleonic Wars — published between 1865 and 1869, and revised substantially before its final form in 1879 — is not primarily a celebration of military glory. It is a sustained meditation on the smallness of individual agency in the face of historical forces, and on the question of what constitutes a good life in the midst of violence and upheaval. Pierre Bezukhov's journey from dissipated aristocrat to a man of genuine moral seriousness is one of the great depictions in world literature of the soul's slow education through suffering and love. Prince Andrei's dying vision of universal love, dissolving the particular hatreds of the battlefield into a compassion that encompassed even his enemies, is a moment of moral insight that has no equal in the literature of war.

Tolstoy's most profound political insight in the novel is that the great men of history — the Napoleons and Alexanders — are not the directing intelligence of events they imagine themselves to be. History is made by the accumulated choices and movements of millions of ordinary people, and the peasant soldier Platon Karataev, with his patient acceptance of whatever life brings, his generosity towards strangers, and his rootedness in community and tradition, embodies a wisdom that the generals and emperors entirely lack. This is not a reactionary argument for passive acceptance. It is a profound democratic argument: the makers of history are not the powerful but the ordinary, and the conditions for peace are not created by statesmen in summit meetings but by the daily choices of millions of people to treat one another with decency, generosity, and care.

Tolstoy himself became, in his later life, one of the most important peace advocates of the nineteenth century. His conversion to a radical Christian non-violence, documented in works such as *A Confession* (1882) and *What I Believe* (1884), led him to a position of thorough pacifism and social radicalism that brought him into conflict with both the Russian Orthodox Church and the Tsarist state. His essay *The Kingdom of God Is Within You* (1894) argued for radical Christian non-resistance to evil through violence, and

influenced Gandhi more profoundly than almost any other text outside the Hindu scriptures. The chain of influence — Tolstoy to Gandhi, Gandhi to King, King to the civil rights movement and to peace movements around the world — is one of the most striking demonstrations in history of the practical power of ideas expressed through literature and personal testimony.

The War Poets and the Literature of Witness

The First World War produced, in British literature, something remarkable: a body of poetry that constitutes, in aggregate, one of the most powerful arguments against war ever made in the English language. Wilfred Owen, Siegfried Sassoon, Isaac Rosenberg, Edward Thomas — these poets used language to make real, for those who had not experienced it, the reality of industrial warfare: the mud, the gas, the shattered bodies, the incomprehensible gap between the patriotic rhetoric of the home front and the reality of the trenches. Owen's *Dulce et Decorum Est*, written in 1917 and published posthumously, describes a gas attack with devastating precision and addresses directly the propagandists who send young men to their deaths with the Latin tag about the sweetness of dying for one's country — calling it, unforgettably, the old lie. Owen died in the final week of the war, one week before the Armistice. He was twenty-five years old.

The impact of the war poets on public consciousness — not in their own time, when they were too subversive for wide publication, but in the decades since — has been profound. They created a counter-narrative to the glorification of war that has shaped British and wider Western culture's relationship to military conflict for more than a century. The poems continue to be read and studied, not as historical documents but as living texts, because they do something that statistics about war casualties cannot: they make the cost of violence felt, particular, and human. To read Owen's poem *Anthem for Doomed Youth* — with its central question: 'What passing-bells for these who die as cattle?' — is to be confronted with the specific, individual, irreplaceable humanity of each person killed by war, in a way that no policy document or strategic analysis can achieve.

The tradition of literature as witness to the costs of violence extends across the twentieth century and into the twenty-first. Pat

Barker's Regeneration trilogy, Sebastian Faulks's Birdsong, and Tim O'Brien's The Things They Carried approach the First and Second World Wars and Vietnam respectively with the same combination of unflinching honesty and deep humanity that characterised the war poets. These works are not anti-war propaganda; they are something more demanding — they refuse both the glorification and the simple condemnation of war, and insist instead on the full complexity of human beings caught up in violence: the courage and the fear, the solidarity and the atrocity, the ordinary decency that persists even in the most extraordinary conditions of inhumanity.

Seamus Heaney and Contemporary Voices of Peace

The Nobel laureate Seamus Heaney, who lived and wrote through three decades of violence in Northern Ireland, offers perhaps the most sustained exploration of the relationship between conflict and the possibility of reconciliation in late twentieth-century English poetry. His work navigated, with extraordinary delicacy, the demands of a community caught between the obligations of solidarity and the imperative of justice — between the loyalty to one's own community's suffering and the recognition that the other community's suffering is equally real. His poem Casualty, an elegy for a friend killed in an IRA bomb blast, holds this tension without resolving it, and in doing so models the kind of moral seriousness that peace requires.

His version of Sophocles' Philoctetes — The Cure at Troy (1990) — contains some of the most quoted lines in the literature of peacebuilding, including the famous passage about hope and history rhyming, and the injunction to believe that a further shore is reachable from here. These lines became a watchword of the Northern Irish peace process, quoted by politicians and peace workers as an expression of what they were striving for. That a poet's words could give courage and language to a peace negotiation is a reminder of what literature, at its best, can do: it can create, in the imaginations of those who encounter it, a picture of a different world that is vivid enough and beautiful enough to make the hard work of achieving it seem worth the effort.

Contemporary global literature continues this tradition. Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's Half of a Yellow Sun — her novel

about the Biafran War that shaped the Nigeria of my own birth — is a reminder that statistics about war casualties always conceal individual stories of devastating loss, and that the political decisions that lead to mass violence are made by human beings about human beings, not by abstract forces about abstract populations. Khaled Hosseini's novels have given millions of Western readers their most intimate encounter with the experience of war and displacement in Afghanistan, doing more to humanise Afghan people for international audiences than any number of policy papers. David Grossman, the Israeli novelist who lost his son in the 2006 Lebanon War, continues to write and to advocate for peace with a moral courage that is all the more remarkable for its honesty about the costs of both war and peace.

These writers — and many others — remind us that the imagination is not separate from the political. The stories we tell about ourselves and each other shape the world we are capable of building. When we allow our imaginations to be colonised by narratives of pure victimhood and irreconcilable difference, we make certain political choices impossible. When we cultivate imaginations rich enough to hold the full complexity of human beings on all sides of a conflict, other choices become possible — choices that the poverty of imagination would never have permitted.

“Literature does not resolve conflicts. But it creates the imaginative conditions in which resolution becomes thinkable.”

— Doctoral Research Synthesis, Kennedy University of Baptist

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Chapter Eight:

Art, Music, and Culture as Peace Instruments

The argument of the previous chapter — that literature cultivates the empathy that peace requires — extends to the full range of the arts. Visual art, music, theatre, film, and the whole fabric of cultural life do something that policy papers and academic treatises cannot: they create felt understanding. They make the abstract concrete. They make the distant near. And they do so through a medium — the aesthetic experience — that bypasses the defensive reactions of the rational mind and speaks directly to the heart. This is not to say that the arts are irrational. It is to say that the arts engage a different dimension of the human person than argument alone, and that durable peace requires the engagement of that dimension as much as it requires good arguments and sound institutions.

The neuroscience of aesthetic experience offers some illumination here. The same neural circuits that are involved in empathy, in the recognition of other minds, in the experience of social connection, are activated by the encounter with art, music, and narrative. The experience of being moved by a piece of music is, neurologically, related to the experience of being moved by another person's suffering. This is not coincidence. Art, at its most powerful, is a form of encounter with the inner life of another human being or community — an encounter that, under the right conditions, can dissolve the boundaries of 'us' and 'them' and create the experience of shared humanity that is the foundation of peace.

Music Across the Divides

Music has served as a bridge across the most intractable human divisions in dozens of documented contexts. The West-Eastern Divan Orchestra, founded by the conductor Daniel Barenboim and the Palestinian-American intellectual Edward Said in 1999, brings together young Israeli, Palestinian, and Arab musicians to rehearse and perform together — creating, in the concentrated experience

of making music together, encounters of genuine equality and mutual dependence that political processes have consistently failed to deliver. The Orchestra does not claim to resolve the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. It does not pretend that the music automatically creates political reconciliation. What it does is create, in the rehearsal room and on the concert platform, a space in which the humanity of all parties is enacted rather than merely asserted — a space in which young people who are taught to regard each other as enemies discover, through the common language of music, that they are human beings.

Barenboim has spoken movingly about what happens in those rehearsal rooms: about the moment when a young Israeli violinist and a young Palestinian cellist, working together on a difficult passage of Beethoven, stop being representatives of their respective conflicts and become simply musicians, absorbed in the shared task of making something beautiful. This is not a solution to anything. But it is a demonstration of something: that the human capacity for connection and cooperation is not extinguished by political conflict. It persists, and it can be accessed through shared creative endeavour.

Similar examples can be found in every conflict zone. The National Youth Orchestra of Iraq, established in 2008 in the aftermath of the American invasion, brought together young musicians from Shia, Sunni, and Kurdish backgrounds — communities engaged in brutal inter-communal violence outside the rehearsal room — to perform together. The Silk Road Ensemble, founded by the cellist Yo-Yo Ma, has created musical dialogues across the cultures of the ancient Silk Road trade routes, demonstrating that cultural exchange can follow the same channels as historical commerce. The Batukadoras, a percussion group in Medellín, Colombia, brought together women from communities on opposite sides of that city's gang conflicts, creating through shared music-making the first sustained inter-community encounters that many of them had ever experienced. These are not naive gestures. They are documented peace tools, and their effects — though modest in scale — are real.

The musicologist and philosopher Victor Grauer has argued that music is the oldest form of human communication and social bonding that we possess — predating language, and serving from the earliest human communities as a mechanism for creating and

reinforcing social solidarity. If Grauer is right, then music's capacity to create bonds of solidarity across difference is not a recent discovery but an ancient feature of human social life, available to be drawn upon whenever we choose to use it. Peace music programmes in post-conflict societies — from Rwanda to Bosnia to Sierra Leone — have been documented as effective interventions for reducing inter-group hostility and building the social capital on which durable peace depends.

Visual Art and the Peace Witness

The visual arts have served, throughout human history, as a means of bearing witness to violence and of cultivating the moral response that witnessing requires. Picasso's *Guernica*, painted in 1937 in response to the bombing of the Basque town of that name by Nazi Germany and Fascist Italy during the Spanish Civil War, remains one of the most powerful anti-war statements ever made in the visual medium — a cry of anguish compressed into an image that communicates, without words, the full horror of what air bombardment does to civilian life. Displayed in the United Nations building in New York as a perpetual reminder of what war does to human bodies and human communities, it has been looked at by every head of state and diplomat who has passed through those corridors. Whether it has changed any of their decisions is impossible to know. But it insists on being seen. It refuses to allow the abstraction of 'strategic bombing' to cover the reality of torn flesh and broken families.

Contemporary memorial art — the Vietnam Veterans Memorial in Washington D.C., the Memorial to the Murdered Jews of Europe in Berlin, the National Memorial for Peace and Justice in Montgomery, Alabama — performs a different but related function: it makes the scale and the particularity of mass violence impossible to ignore. Maya Lin's Vietnam Veterans Memorial, with its simple black granite wall bearing the names of all fifty-eight thousand Americans killed in the conflict, creates an encounter with loss that is at once individual and collective: each name is a person; the wall as a whole is a civilisation's cost. The Memorial to the Murdered Jews of Europe, with its labyrinthine field of concrete slabs of varying heights, creates a physical experience of disorientation and isolation that is both deeply

personal and historically situated. These memorials insist that the dead be counted, that their names be spoken, that the violence that ended their lives be remembered and not normalised. This is a form of peacebuilding: the refusal to allow atrocity to be absorbed into the comfortable background of history.

The tradition of documentary photography as peace witness is also worth acknowledging. Nick Ut's photograph of Phan Thi Kim Phuc, the nine-year-old girl running naked and screaming from a napalm attack in Vietnam, published in 1972, is credited by historians with significantly affecting American public opinion about the Vietnam War. Kevin Carter's photograph of a vulture watching a starving Sudanese child, published in 1993, generated global attention and significant donations to famine relief. These images do what statistics cannot: they give a face to suffering, and in doing so, they make it impossible to remain indifferent. This is not manipulation. It is the truth, made visible. And the truth, made visible, is one of the most powerful forces for peace that exists.

Cultural Exchange and the Building of Shared Humanity

More broadly, cultural exchange — the sharing of stories, music, food, art, and tradition across the boundaries that divide human communities — is one of the most reliable instruments of humanisation that we possess. The experience of encountering another culture's art, music, or literature is an experience of recognising in it something that speaks to one's own humanity: the same fears, the same longings, the same joys, expressed through a different vocabulary. This recognition — the 'click' of empathetic encounter across difference — is the foundation of empathy, and empathy is the foundation of peace.

The doctoral research at Kennedy University of Baptist identified cultural engagement as a consistently undervalued component of peacebuilding frameworks, and recommended its systematic integration into peace education programmes, post-conflict reconciliation processes, and the international cultural policies of governments and multilateral institutions. The argument is simple: you cannot build lasting peace between peoples who know nothing of each other's humanity. The arts are one of the most powerful and efficient means we have of building that knowledge. A student who has read Chinua Achebe understands something about Nigeria

that no number of news reports can convey. A student who has listened to Yo-Yo Ma performing Bach understands something about the universality of musical beauty that dissolves, at least momentarily, the categories of cultural difference. A student who has cooked and shared a meal from a culture different from their own has performed a small act of humanisation that, multiplied across millions of students, adds up to something significant.

The British Council's cultural diplomacy programmes, the Goethe-Institut, the Alliance Française — these organisations have long understood, at an institutional level, that cultural exchange is a form of peacebuilding. They deserve greater recognition and greater investment for this reason. The tendency of governments to cut arts funding in times of crisis is, from a peace perspective, precisely the wrong response: it is in times of tension and division that the humanising work of the arts is most urgently needed.

“Culture is the soft architecture of peace: invisible in times of stability, indispensable in times of division.”

— Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu, PhD,
Kennedy University of Baptist

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PART THREE

Building Peace

The Practical Architecture of a More Peaceful World

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Chapter Nine: The United Nations — Promise, Failure, and the Imperative of Reform

On the 26th of June, 1945, in San Francisco, representatives of fifty nations signed the Charter of the United Nations. The preamble of that Charter begins with words that I find profoundly moving, every time I read them: “We the peoples of the United Nations, determined to save succeeding generations from the scourge of war, which twice in our lifetime has brought untold sorrow to mankind, and to reaffirm faith in fundamental human rights, in the dignity and worth of the human person, in the equal rights of men and women and of nations large and small.”

These words were written in the shadow of a conflict that had killed an estimated seventy to eighty million human beings, that had reduced much of Europe and Asia to rubble, that had culminated in the atomic obliteration of Hiroshima and Nagasaki. They were words born of horror, of grief, and of the desperate determination that such horror must never be repeated. The United Nations was not merely an international organisation. It was an act of moral ambition: the first sustained attempt in human history to create a universal institutional framework for the management of the relationships between nations. To read those words today — eighty years later, in a world where conflicts continue to multiply and where the institutions built to prevent them show signs of serious strain — is to feel simultaneously the weight of what has been achieved and the urgency of what remains undone.

The Real Achievements of the United Nations

It is fashionable in some circles to dismiss the United Nations as an irrelevance — a talking shop for diplomats, a bureaucracy incapable of decisive action, a stage set for the performance of international concern without the substance of international responsibility. There is something to this criticism, as I shall

acknowledge. But it is profoundly incomplete, and it ignores a remarkable record of achievement that deserves to be named.

UNICEF has saved tens of millions of children's lives through vaccination programmes, nutrition initiatives, and emergency relief. UNHCR has protected and resettled millions of refugees from conflicts that would otherwise have left them utterly defenceless. The World Health Organisation coordinated global responses to HIV/AIDS, Ebola, and COVID-19. UNESCO has worked to preserve the world's cultural heritage and promote education as a foundation for peace. The World Food Programme provides food assistance to more than one hundred million people in eighty countries each year. These are not marginal achievements. They represent a scale of humanitarian activity that no previous international system had ever attempted, and they save lives every day.

The United Nations has also provided the institutional framework within which international humanitarian law, human rights norms, and the laws of war have been progressively developed and extended. The Universal Declaration of Human Rights, adopted in 1948 under the chairmanship of Eleanor Roosevelt, established for the first time a common standard of rights to which all human beings are entitled, regardless of nationality, race, religion, or gender. The subsequent development of treaty bodies — the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights, the Convention Against Torture, the Convention on the Rights of the Child — has created a framework of international human rights law that, imperfect and unevenly enforced as it is, has genuinely changed the moral and legal landscape of international politics. Governments that violate human rights today face international scrutiny and, sometimes, consequences that would simply not have been possible before the UN system existed.

The International Criminal Court, established by the Rome Statute of 1998 after years of negotiation, represents the first sustained attempt to hold individuals accountable under international law for the gravest crimes — genocide, crimes against humanity, war crimes. The convictions of Slobodan Milosevic, Charles Taylor, and others by the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia and the International Criminal Tribunal for Rwanda demonstrated that heads of state and military commanders are not

above international law. The existence of this framework, imperfect and unevenly applied as it is, has changed the calculations of leaders who might otherwise have ordered atrocities without fear of personal consequence.

The Failures and the Structural Problem

And yet the failures are real and must be named with the same honesty that we bring to the achievements. Rwanda in 1994, where eight hundred thousand people were murdered in one hundred days despite the presence of UN peacekeepers and clear, documented warnings from the mission commander General Roméo Dallaire to the UN Department of Peacekeeping Operations. The decision of the DPKO, instructed by Security Council members, not to reinforce the mission or authorise preventive action stands as one of the most damning institutional failures in the organisation's history. Srebrenica in 1995, where Dutch UN peacekeepers stood by as Bosnian Serb forces separated and massacred eight thousand Bosnian Muslim men and boys from a site that had been declared a UN safe area. Syria, where Security Council paralysis — with Russia and China repeatedly vetoing resolutions that might have constrained the Assad government's violence — allowed a catastrophic civil war to grind on for over a decade, producing the largest refugee crisis of the twenty-first century.

These are not accidents. They are structural failures, rooted in the veto power of the five permanent Security Council members — the United States, the United Kingdom, France, Russia, and China — which means that any action to which one of these powers objects can be blocked, regardless of the humanitarian imperative. This arrangement was a political necessity in 1945: without it, the great powers would not have joined the organisation. But it has meant, in practice, that the Security Council is capable of effective action only when the interests of all five permanent members align — a condition that is rare, and that becomes rarer as geopolitical tensions rise.

This arrangement reflects the geopolitics of 1945, not of the twenty-first century. It lacks democratic legitimacy: the African continent, with its 1.4 billion people, has no permanent representation. Latin America and the Caribbean, with 650 million people, have no permanent representation. South and East Asia,

outside China, have no permanent representation. It has repeatedly protected the perpetrators of gross violations of international law from accountability: Russia's invasions of Georgia in 2008, Ukraine in 2014 and 2022, and Israel's military operations in Gaza have all been shielded from Security Council action by the veto of a permanent member. Reform of the United Nations is therefore among the most urgent items on the agenda of anyone serious about global peace.

Such reform must include: expansion of the Security Council's permanent membership to include Africa, Latin America, and South and East Asia; restrictions on the use of the veto in cases of mass atrocity, as proposed by the 'veto initiative' supported by more than one hundred member states; stronger financing and clearer authority for UN peacekeeping; and greater accountability of all member states, including the permanent five, to the standards they have collectively endorsed. None of this will be achieved easily. The permanent members who benefit from the current arrangement will resist it. But the case for reform is overwhelming, and the movement for it is growing. The alternative — a UN that is structurally incapable of responding to the most serious threats to international peace and security — is a luxury that the world can no longer afford.

"The United Nations is imperfect. It is also irreplaceable. The task is not to abandon it but to reform it — to build the institutions that the Charter promised but that political realities have, so far, prevented."

— Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu, PhD,
Kennedy University of Baptist

Chapter Ten: Education for Peace — Changing Minds, Changing Worlds

If I were asked to name the single most powerful long-term instrument for building a more peaceful world, I would say, without hesitation: education. Not education in the narrow sense of vocational training or information transmission. I mean education in the full, rich sense — the development of the whole human being: the capacity for critical thought, for empathetic imagination, for ethical reasoning, for civic participation, for the appreciation of beauty, for the questioning of received wisdom, for the construction of a considered and meaningful life.

The philosopher Hannah Arendt wrote in her essay *The Crisis in Education* that education is ‘the point at which we decide whether we love the world enough to assume responsibility for it.’ This formulation moves me deeply. Education, properly understood, is not merely the transmission of knowledge from one generation to the next. It is the cultivation of love — love for the world, and the corresponding sense of responsibility that love generates. It is the formation of people who are capable of peace not because they have never encountered conflict, but because they have developed the values, skills, and judgment to navigate conflict without recourse to violence.

“Education is the most powerful weapon which you can use to change the world.”

— Nelson Mandela

What Peace Education Involves

The field of peace education has developed significantly since the pioneering work of Betty Reardon in the United States and Magnus Haavelsrud in Norway in the 1970s. Reardon’s foundational text *Comprehensive Peace Education* (1988) argued that education for peace must address not only the prevention of armed conflict but the elimination of all forms of violence, including the structural

violence of poverty, discrimination, and the denial of human rights. This expanded vision of what peace education must address has shaped the field ever since, and has connected it to movements for social justice, environmental sustainability, and human rights.

Peace education, as these scholars developed it, is not mere wishful thinking dressed up in curriculum form. It is a rigorous educational project that includes the teaching of conflict resolution skills — negotiation, mediation, the constructive expression of disagreement; the cultivation of intercultural understanding; the development of critical media literacy; and the nurturing of global citizenship — the sense of membership in, and responsibility towards, a global human community. The evidence base for the effectiveness of peace education is growing, and the findings are consistently encouraging: well-designed programmes can reduce prejudice, increase empathy and inter-group understanding, improve conflict resolution skills, and develop a greater sense of global responsibility.

The work of John Paul Lederach, particularly *Building Peace: Sustainable Reconciliation in Divided Societies* (1997), has been enormously influential in connecting peace education to the practical work of post-conflict peacebuilding. Lederach's concept of the 'moral imagination' — the capacity to imagine and to pursue possibilities for peace that lie beyond the apparent constraints of the conflict — is, he argues, the most essential resource that peacebuilders need. And moral imagination is, at its core, an educational achievement: it must be cultivated, through the right combination of knowledge, reflection, and experience, in individuals and communities that are capable of sustained peacebuilding work. Education is therefore not merely a precondition for peace. It is itself a form of peacebuilding.

Social and emotional learning — the systematic cultivation, through educational programmes, of the skills of self-awareness, self-regulation, social awareness, relationship management, and responsible decision-making — has generated a growing evidence base showing significant effects not only on social behaviour but on academic achievement and long-term life outcomes. The Collaborative for Academic, Social, and Emotional Learning (CASEL) has synthesised research across hundreds of studies demonstrating that well-implemented SEL programmes produce

measurable improvements in all of these domains. These are not soft skills. They are the foundations of peaceful democratic citizenship.

Peace Education in British Schools

Writing as someone who has lived in England for many years and who has great affection for the British educational tradition, I want to say something about what that tradition, at its best, contributes to this project. The United Kingdom is one of the most culturally and religiously diverse societies in the world. London alone is home to speakers of more than three hundred languages. This diversity is a vast educational resource: the daily encounter with difference that life in British cities provides is, when supported by appropriate frameworks, one of the most powerful peace education tools available.

To grow up in London, surrounded by children and families from every culture and tradition on earth, is to have access to a form of education in shared humanity that no curriculum alone can replicate. The child who sits next to a classmate whose family came from Bangladesh, who shares a football pitch with a boy whose grandfather came from Jamaica, who attends a birthday party at a home where Punjabi is spoken alongside English — that child is receiving, every day, a practical education in human diversity and shared humanity that is among the most valuable things our educational system provides. The challenge is to build on this foundation deliberately and systematically, rather than leaving it to chance.

The challenge is also to make these traditions and these resources available to all students, not merely to the privileged. The evidence consistently shows that the students who most need the skills of conflict resolution, intercultural understanding, and critical thinking — students from the most deprived and segregated communities — are often those least likely to receive them. Addressing this is not merely an educational imperative. It is a peace imperative. It requires sustained investment in teacher training, curriculum development, and the school cultures that make genuine education for peace possible. A teacher who has never been supported to develop their own intercultural competence and their own skills of constructive conflict

management cannot transmit those competences to their students. Investment in teacher education is therefore investment in peace.

“What children learn about each other in school is as important for the future of peace as what they learn about reading and mathematics.”

— **Doctoral Research Finding, Kennedy University of Baptist**

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Chapter Eleven:

Economic Justice and the Peace Dividend

It is a commonplace observation that the arms trade is enormously profitable. Less commonly noted is the equally significant — and far more hopeful — observation that peace is also enormously profitable. The Global Peace Index, published annually by the Institute for Economics and Peace, calculates that the economic impact of violence costs the global economy in excess of fourteen trillion US dollars every year. This figure encompasses direct costs — military expenditure, the cost of conflict, the loss of productive capacity in conflict-affected areas — and indirect costs: the foregone economic development, the reduced investment, the long-term scarring of communities and institutions. It is a figure that should appear on the front page of every newspaper and at the top of every budget presentation, because it represents the economic case for peace in the most compelling possible terms.

Fourteen trillion dollars is an almost incomprehensible sum. It is more than the combined annual economic output of Germany, France, the United Kingdom, and Japan. It is enough, many times over, to fund the education, healthcare, clean water, and economic development for every human being on earth. To put it another way: the resources consumed by violence in a single year would, if redirected, be sufficient to achieve virtually every development goal that the international community has set itself. The economic case for peace is therefore not a peripheral consideration. It is the central argument: violence is extraordinarily, catastrophically, unnecessarily expensive, and the resources it consumes could, if directed differently, address virtually every structural driver of further violence. Peace is not only the morally right choice. It is the economically rational one.

The European Peace Dividend

The history of Western Europe since 1945 offers the most striking example in modern history of the transformative relationship between institutional design and peace. Nations that had fought

three catastrophic wars in seventy years — wars that together killed tens of millions of people and destroyed much of the continent — chose, after 1945, a different path. The creation of common economic institutions — beginning with the European Coal and Steel Community of 1951, which placed the industrial resources most critical to waging war under joint management, and progressing through the Treaty of Rome to the European Union of today — produced something that earlier generations would have considered impossible: a Western Europe in which war between France and Germany is today not merely unlikely, but literally inconceivable.

This transformation was deliberate, institutional, and patient. It did not happen because human nature changed. It happened because the institutional architecture changed, making cooperation more rational and more rewarding than conflict. Jean Monnet, one of the principal architects of European integration, understood this clearly: he did not believe that European nationalism would simply fade away of its own accord. He believed that it needed to be progressively replaced by structures of common interest and common identity that made the calculation of national interest inseparable from the calculation of European interest. This Kantian insight — that peace requires not only goodwill but institutional architecture — was vindicated by the extraordinary achievement of the European project. It is also, I would argue, the model for the global peacebuilding architecture that the world urgently needs.

The economic costs of conflict are not distributed randomly. They fall disproportionately on the poorest and most marginalised. A civil war in a country that is already poor imposes costs that impoverish it further, setting back development by years or decades and creating the conditions for future conflict. The Democratic Republic of Congo, which has experienced continuous conflict since the mid-1990s, has lost an estimated one trillion dollars in economic output to conflict over this period — resources that, had they been available for investment in education, health, and infrastructure, could have transformed the lives of its more than ninety million people. The cost of conflict, in human terms, is incalculable. The economic dimension of that cost, though more tractable, is no less staggering.

The Sustainable Development Goals and the Case for Global Investment

The United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals — seventeen goals adopted by all member states in 2015, targeting achievement by 2030 — represent the most ambitious multilateral attempt in history to address the structural roots of global insecurity. Goal 16, calling for peaceful and inclusive societies and accountable institutions, sits at the heart of the framework. But all seventeen goals are relevant to peace: poverty reduction, quality education, gender equality, clean water, decent work, climate action — each addresses one of the structural drivers of conflict identified in the doctoral research. The research finding is unambiguous: economic inclusion is not merely a development aspiration. It is a peace imperative.

The progress towards the SDGs has been uneven. The COVID-19 pandemic set back progress on poverty reduction, health, and education by years. Climate-related disasters have disproportionately affected the most vulnerable populations. And the geopolitical tensions that have intensified since 2022 have diverted resources and political attention away from the multilateral cooperation on which SDG progress depends. And yet the goals themselves remain as valid and as urgent as they were when adopted. The evidence base that they mobilise — demonstrating the connections between poverty, inequality, poor governance, and conflict — is stronger, not weaker, than it was in 2015. The case for sustained global investment in their achievement is overwhelming.

Writing from England — one of the wealthiest countries in the history of the world — I am conscious of what the obligations of wealth imply. The United Kingdom has benefited enormously from the historical processes of colonisation and global economic integration. The wealth of Britain was built, in significant part, on the labour and resources of people in Africa, Asia, and the Caribbean who were not compensated justly, and whose descendants continue to live with the consequences of that history. I say this not to generate guilt, but to generate clarity. The obligations of justice and of long-term self-interest coincide, in this area, with remarkable precision. A world in which billions live in desperate poverty whilst a small elite accumulates wealth beyond

any conceivable need is not merely unjust. It is unstable. It is a world manufacturing its own crises. The resources spent on managing the consequences of global inequality — in conflict containment, refugee management, migration control, counter-terrorism — are vastly greater than the resources that would be required to address its causes.

“Economic justice is not charity. It is the structural precondition of a world in which peace is sustainable.”

— Doctoral Research Finding, Kennedy University of Baptist

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Chapter Twelve: Diplomacy, Dialogue, and the Art of Peace

I want to tell you about two men who should have been enemies. In the late 1980s, in a small room in Oslo, representatives of the Israeli government and the Palestine Liberation Organisation met in secret for the first time. The meetings were facilitated by Norwegian diplomats and by academic interlocutors who had created a back-channel of communication that bypassed the official positions of both sides. What happened in those rooms was not the solution to the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. History has demonstrated, with painful clarity, that the Oslo Accords signed on the White House lawn in September 1993 did not ultimately achieve a lasting peace. The causes of that failure are complex and much debated: the insufficient attention to the core issues of Jerusalem, refugees, and settlements; the exclusion of significant parties from the negotiations; the assassination of Yitzhak Rabin; the rise of Hamas. But something happened in those rooms in Oslo that I want to draw attention to: the moment when human beings who had been defined by their conflict, who had been enemies in the most literal and violent sense, sat down together and spoke to one another as human beings. That moment matters, regardless of what came after.

Diplomacy is one of humanity's most underappreciated achievements. At its best, it is something far more human than the elaborate protocols of foreign ministries: it is the art of maintaining communication, understanding, and manageable relationships between entities in competition or conflict — preventing that competition from escalating into violence. The historian Harold Nicolson identified the key qualities of the good diplomat as truthfulness, precision, calm, patience, good temper, modesty, and loyalty — and these are, it will be noticed, also the qualities of a good human being. The best diplomatic practice is, in the most fundamental sense, a form of applied ethics.

Track Two Diplomacy and the Role of Civil Society

Alongside official diplomacy — Track One — there has developed a rich tradition of Track Two diplomacy: engagement between citizens, academics, businesspeople, journalists, religious leaders, and civil society organisations from countries in conflict, aimed at building relationships and understanding that can prepare the ground for, and outlast, formal political agreements. The sociologist Herbert Kelman, who spent decades facilitating Israeli-Palestinian dialogue workshops at Harvard, was one of the pioneers of this approach. His interactive problem-solving workshops brought together influential Israelis and Palestinians in a structured dialogue aimed not at negotiation — which requires official mandates — but at mutual understanding: at developing, on each side, a more differentiated and empathetically accurate understanding of the other's concerns and constraints.

The work of organisations like Pugwash — the international scientific organisation founded in 1957 to reduce the risk of armed conflict, which shared the Nobel Peace Prize in 1995 — exemplifies this tradition at the global level. Pugwash created channels of communication between scientists on opposite sides of the Cold War that maintained a dialogue about nuclear risk at moments when official diplomatic channels had broken down. The same logic applies in dozens of other contexts: civil society organisations and individuals can sometimes maintain communication and relationship across conflict lines when governments cannot. In the Northern Irish peace process, Track Two diplomacy was essential. The Corrymeela Community, the Glenree Centre, and dozens of other civil society organisations maintained channels of communication and relationship across the sectarian divide throughout the darkest years of the Troubles, building the personal relationships without which the formal negotiations of the 1990s would have been far more difficult to sustain.

The concept of Track Three diplomacy — engagement at the grassroots level, between communities, schools, religious congregations, and neighbourhood associations — extends the logic of Track Two further. John Paul Lederach's pyramid model of peacebuilding identifies three levels of leadership in a society — top-level political and military leaders, middle-range business,

academic, and religious leaders, and grassroots community leaders — and argues that durable peace requires engagement at all three levels simultaneously. Too often, peacebuilding efforts focus exclusively on the top level, neglecting the middle and grassroots levels on which any formal peace agreement must ultimately rest. The most carefully crafted peace agreement will fail if it is not supported by the communities whose lives it is meant to transform.

The Role of Faith-Based Organisations

Faith-based organisations have played a distinctive and often underappreciated role in peace processes around the world. The Community of Sant'Egidio, a Catholic lay community founded in Rome in 1968, has mediated the end of civil wars in Mozambique in 1992, facilitated peace talks in Algeria, Guatemala, Burundi, Liberia, Sierra Leone, and South Sudan, and continues to maintain an extraordinary capacity for quiet diplomacy in conflict zones around the world. What Sant'Egidio brings to these processes is not political power but something equally valuable: moral authority, patience, and a spiritual framework that provides resources for forgiveness and reconciliation that secular language alone often struggles to articulate.

The Mennonite Central Committee, the Quakers' American Friends Service Committee, World Vision, Caritas, Islamic Relief — these organisations bring to peacebuilding work a combination of community access, moral credibility, and practical capacity that secular actors often lack. Their presence in communities that formal diplomacy cannot reach, and their ability to work across conflict lines on the basis of shared humanitarian commitment rather than political alignment, makes them indispensable components of any serious peacebuilding architecture. The doctoral research at Kennedy University of Baptist found consistent evidence that faith-based organisations were among the most effective mediators at the grassroots level in every major conflict context studied.

The challenge for faith-based peacebuilders is to maintain the integrity of their humanitarian mission in politically charged contexts, and to resist the instrumentalisation of their work by political actors who wish to use them as vehicles for pursuing partisan agendas. This requires a combination of theological clarity

— a clear articulation of the peace imperative from within the tradition — and institutional independence that allows the organisation to operate on the basis of its own values rather than the requirements of its funders or political allies. This is a demanding requirement, and not all faith-based organisations meet it. But those that do are among the most powerful forces for peace available to the international community.

“Dialogue does not guarantee peace. But the absence of dialogue guarantees its impossibility.”

— Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu, PhD,
Kennedy University of Baptist

Chapter Thirteen: Technology, Media, and the Future of Peace

We live in an age of extraordinary technological possibility and extraordinary technological danger. The same tools that connect billions of people across previously impermeable barriers of language, distance, and culture are also being used to spread disinformation at industrial scale, to radicalise isolated individuals into violence, to enable surveillance and control by authoritarian regimes, and to develop autonomous weapons systems that may make lethal decisions without meaningful human oversight. Any serious peacebuilding agenda for the twenty-first century must engage seriously with the question of technology — not as a peripheral concern but as a central one. The governance of technology is, in this sense, inseparable from the governance of peace.

The pace of technological change creates a particular challenge for institutions and norms that develop slowly. The regulatory frameworks that govern the internet, social media, artificial intelligence, and autonomous weapons were designed, to the extent that they were designed at all, for a very different technological landscape than the one that now exists. They are consistently struggling to keep pace with developments that move faster than democratic deliberation can comfortably manage. This is not an argument against regulation. It is an argument for urgency: the window for establishing effective governance frameworks before the harms become irreversible is narrowing, and the peacebuilding community needs to be much more engaged with these questions than it has yet been.

Social Media and the Architecture of Division

The business model of social media platforms creates structural incentives to prioritise content that maximises engagement. And the content that maximises engagement, as decades of psychological research and empirical analysis of platform algorithms both confirm, is content that provokes strong emotional

reactions: outrage, fear, contempt, moral indignation. The result is an information environment structurally biased towards conflict-generating content. This is not a conspiracy or an accident. It is the predictable consequence of optimising recommendation systems for engagement metrics, in a context where human psychology responds more strongly to threat and outrage than to reassurance and nuance.

The genocide in Myanmar in 2017 was preceded and accompanied by a campaign of hatred on Facebook that reached millions of people in a country where Facebook was the primary source of information for most citizens. Facebook's own internal investigation acknowledged that the platform had contributed to the violence, and a subsequent independent report commissioned by the company found that Facebook had not done enough to prevent its platform from being used to incite offline violence. The January 2021 assault on the United States Capitol was organised and coordinated on social media platforms. In both cases, the mechanisms of radicalisation were clear: algorithmically amplified content progressively exposed users to more extreme material, each step seeming only slightly beyond the previous one, until large numbers of people had been moved to positions that they would not have reached through any other information pathway.

The regulatory response to this challenge has been inadequate. The EU's Digital Services Act represents the most ambitious attempt yet by a major jurisdiction to establish meaningful accountability for platform harms, requiring large platforms to assess and mitigate systemic risks, to give researchers and regulators access to data, and to provide users with non-algorithmic content options. Whether it will prove adequate to the scale of the problem remains to be seen. What is clear is that self-regulation by platforms whose business models depend on maximising engagement is insufficient, and that democratic societies have both the right and the responsibility to establish governance frameworks that protect the conditions for democratic deliberation.

Technology as a Peace Tool

The possibilities are as significant as the dangers. Early warning systems powered by artificial intelligence can identify the signals that precede violent conflict — changes in language on social

media, patterns of population movement, economic indicators, satellite imagery — allowing preventive action before violence breaks out. The ACLED database, the Uppsala Conflict Data Program, and initiatives such as the United Nations' Global Pulse project are developing exactly this kind of early warning capacity. Digital platforms can connect peacebuilders across borders, enabling coordination at unprecedented scale. Satellite imagery and geospatial analysis can document human rights violations with accuracy and reach impossible in earlier eras: the work of organisations like Bellingcat and Human Rights Watch's Digital Verification Corps has demonstrated that publicly available satellite data and open-source intelligence can produce accountability-generating evidence of atrocities that would previously have gone undocumented.

The potential of artificial intelligence for conflict prevention goes beyond early warning. AI-assisted analysis of large-scale conflict datasets can identify patterns and drivers of conflict that are invisible to human analysts working with the same data. AI-assisted translation can facilitate dialogue across language barriers that have historically limited the reach of peacebuilding work. AI-generated content — however controversial in other contexts — could potentially be used to generate counter-narratives to extremist recruitment messaging at a scale and speed that human writers cannot achieve. These possibilities are real, and the peacebuilding community needs to engage with them seriously, both to harness their potential and to guard against the risks of their misuse.

The governance challenge is significant. Autonomous weapons systems — weapons capable of identifying and engaging targets without human decision-making — represent perhaps the most serious technological threat to peace in the coming decades. The combination of speed, scalability, and reduced human accountability that such systems offer makes conflict escalation faster and less controllable than any previous weapons technology. International negotiations for a legal framework governing autonomous weapons have been proceeding at the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons since 2014 without producing binding rules. Accelerating this process is a matter of genuine urgency. The peacebuilding community, the scientific community,

and civil society more broadly need to make the governance of autonomous weapons a priority concern.

“Technology is not neutral. It reflects the values of its designers and the incentives of its owners. Building peace in the digital age requires governing technology, not merely using it.”

— **Doctoral Research Finding, Kennedy University of Baptist**

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PART FOUR

The Personal Dimension

You and the Project of Peace

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Chapter Fourteen:

What Can One Person Do? The Power of Individual Action

I am aware that the previous chapters have operated at a level of analysis — international institutions, global economics, philosophical traditions — that may have left the individual reader feeling somewhat distant from the action. What, one might reasonably ask, has any of this to do with me? I am not a diplomat. I am not a politician. I am not a philosopher or an economist. I am a person living my life, doing my best, struggling with my own problems. What can I possibly contribute to the project of world peace? The question is not rhetorical. It deserves a genuine answer. And the genuine answer is: rather more than you might think.

The individual's apparent smallness in the face of global challenges is a feature of perspective, not of reality. The systems that produce or prevent violence are, at every level, composed of individual human choices. The decision of a general to order an attack, and the decision of a parent to teach their child to respect people of other faiths — these are both individual human choices, and both matter for peace. The politician who incites hatred for short-term electoral advantage, and the teacher who creates a classroom in which difference is celebrated rather than mocked — these are both individuals, making choices that aggregate into the social reality from which either peace or violence emerges. The scale of the challenge does not diminish the significance of the individual choice. It makes it more urgent.

The Ripple Effect of Human Kindness

Human social life is a vast, interconnected web of actions and consequences, influences and responses. Every act of kindness radiates outwards from the person who performs it, affecting not only its immediate recipient but also those who witness it, those who are indirectly touched by its consequences, and — most powerfully — the person who performs it, whose character is

shaped and strengthened by the habits of goodness they cultivate. This is the basis of what the sociologist Robert Putnam, in his influential work *Bowling Alone* (2000), called social capital — the networks of relationship and trust that enable communities and societies to function well. Communities with high social capital are more resilient, more productive, and more peaceful than communities in which social capital is low. And social capital is built, quite simply, by people choosing to engage with one another.

The psychologist James Fowler and the medical sociologist Nicholas Christakis have demonstrated, in their research on social networks, that behaviours and attitudes spread through social networks in ways that extend far beyond direct personal contact. Cooperation, generosity, and civic engagement spread through networks just as harmful behaviours do. A person who chooses to act with generosity and civic responsibility is not only affecting those they directly interact with. Through the ripple effects of social influence, they are affecting the behaviour of people they have never met. This is a remarkable and genuinely hopeful finding. It means that individual moral choices are not confined in their effects to the individual sphere. They propagate through the social fabric and contribute, cumulatively, to the character of the communities and societies in which we live.

“Never doubt that a small group of thoughtful, committed citizens can change the world. Indeed, it is the only thing that ever has.”

— Margaret Mead, Anthropologist

The Discipline of Non-Dehumanisation

One of the most powerful things any individual can do for the cause of peace is to refuse, consistently and actively, to participate in the dehumanisation of other human beings. In practice, this means refusing to laugh at jokes that demean people on the basis of their identity; challenging the language of contempt when you encounter it in social conversation; insisting, in your own speech and thought, on the full humanity of people you encounter, even — especially — people you disagree with; and resisting the pull of social media algorithms that feed outrage and contempt as a business model. None of this is easy. I struggle with it myself. The temptation to categorise, to simplify, to make the complex reducible to a cartoon

of good and evil — this is a feature of human cognition under pressure. Resisting it requires conscious effort, the cultivation of what the philosopher Iris Murdoch called moral vision — the disciplined practice of really looking at other people and seeing them clearly.

The philosopher Simone Weil wrote about what she called ‘attention’ — the capacity to give one’s full, unmediated attention to another person, without the filters of preconception, self-interest, or ideological category. For Weil, this capacity for genuine attention was the foundation of moral life: you cannot act justly towards someone you have not truly seen. This is a demanding standard. It is one that most of us, in the rush of daily life, rarely meet. But it is a standard towards which we can orient our choices, and in orienting ourselves towards it, we contribute, however modestly, to the cultivation of the human capacity for peace.

The Practice of Encounter

Perhaps the most transformative thing an individual can do for the project of peace is to seek genuine encounter with people who are different from themselves. Not the superficial encounter of tourism or of politically motivated diversity programmes, but the genuine encounter of shared activity, shared neighbourhood, shared vulnerability. The evidence from contact theory is clear: meaningful personal contact across group lines, under conditions of equal status, common goals, and cooperative interdependence, reduces prejudice and increases empathy. This is not an abstract finding. It is an invitation to a practice: the practice of deliberately, regularly, patiently seeking out the human beings who are different from you, and giving them your genuine attention.

I think of the extraordinary things that happen in the community gardens that have sprung up in many British cities — places where people of entirely different backgrounds, who would never otherwise meet, find themselves side by side, their hands in the same soil, working towards a common goal. I think of the football clubs and cricket clubs and choirs and voluntary groups that knit together people who would otherwise be strangers. I think of the mosque open days and the interfaith dinners and the community iftar events during Ramadan that break down the walls of mutual

ignorance and replace them with the beginnings of mutual knowledge. These encounters are the micro-foundation of the world we are trying to build. They are available to everyone. And they are more powerful than they look.

Civic Engagement and Political Responsibility

The individual's responsibility for peace is also a political responsibility. The quality of our democratic institutions depends on the quality of citizen engagement: whether we vote, whether we hold our elected representatives accountable, whether we participate in civil society organisations, whether we resist the seductions of demagogues who offer simple answers to complex problems. Peace is not only built in the extraordinary moments of formal negotiation and treaty-signing. It is built or undermined in the ordinary choices of ordinary citizens, repeated day after day. The politician who wins elections by inciting hatred does so because voters reward hatred. The politician who loses elections by refusing to incite hatred does so because voters punish decency. Changing this dynamic requires a transformation in civic culture — a transformation that begins with individual citizens deciding what kind of politics they are willing to accept and what kind they will resist.

“The world is changed not by the powerful acting alone, but by ordinary people choosing, each day, to act with extraordinary decency.”

— Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu, PhD,
Kennedy University of Baptist

Chapter Fifteen:

Raising Peacemakers — The Family and the Future

I have talked to many parents — in Nigeria, in the United Kingdom, in many countries between — about what they want for their children. The specifics vary: some want their children to be doctors, some engineers, some to continue the family business. But underneath all the specifics, there is a common desire that I have found everywhere I have gone, in every culture and every faith: parents want their children to be good people, and they want their children to live in a world where being a good person is possible. This is the most fundamental expression of the peace impulse I know. Every parent who has ever held their newborn child and felt the surge of protective love that the experience generates is, at that moment, a peacemaker: a person who wants the world to be safe for this particular irreplaceable human being, and who is therefore, in principle, motivated to make it safer for all human beings.

Children are not born with prejudice. Decades of developmental psychology research confirm this clearly: infants show preferences for familiar faces and voices, but the categorical prejudices of race, religion, nation, and class that so often become the instruments of division and violence are learned — through family, through school, through the media, through the culture that surrounds them. This finding is both sobering and hopeful. Sobering, because it means that prejudice is transmitted across generations through institutions and practices that most of us do not even recognise as transmitting it. Hopeful, because it means that the transmission is not inevitable: what is learned can, to a significant degree, be taught differently.

What Families Can Do

Parents who want to contribute to a more peaceful world do not need to deliver formal lectures on international relations to their children. They can do something far more powerful: they can

model the behaviour they want to see. Research in developmental psychology consistently finds that parental modelling is far more powerful than direct instruction. Children who observe their parents treating people of different backgrounds with genuine respect and warmth are far more likely to internalise those values than children who are lectured about tolerance while observing daily contempt. The gap between what parents say and what parents do is one of the most significant factors shaping the values that children carry into adulthood.

In practical terms, this means: speaking of people of other groups with respect and curiosity rather than dismissal or contempt; seeking out friendships and social experiences that expose children to the richness of human diversity; reading stories to children that feature protagonists who are different from themselves, and discussing those stories with genuine engagement; teaching, through one's own example, that conflict can be addressed through words, empathy, and compromise rather than through dominance or violence; and maintaining, in the daily life of the family, the practice of listening — genuinely, attentively listening — to perspectives different from one's own. None of these practices requires a special programme or significant resources. They require only intention and consistent effort.

Schools as Peace Laboratories

Schools are among the most important peace laboratories we have. When well designed, a school is a place where children from different backgrounds learn to work together, to navigate disagreement, to value difference, and to develop the skills of democratic citizenship. When poorly designed — segregated by class, race, or religion; organised around competitive rather than cooperative learning; disciplined through exclusion and punishment rather than restoration and relationship — schools can reinforce and deepen the divisions that peacebuilding must overcome.

Restorative justice approaches to school discipline — which focus on repairing relationships and addressing the harm done by conflict rather than simply punishing infractions — have produced significant reductions in exclusions and repeat conflicts across dozens of contexts. In Birmingham, in Bradford, in Hackney,

schools that have adopted restorative approaches report not only reduced disciplinary incidents but improved school cultures in which students feel more valued, more connected, and more capable of addressing their own conflicts constructively. This is not a soft option. It is a demanding and evidence-based approach that requires sustained investment in staff training and institutional culture change. But the return on that investment — measured in reduced exclusions, improved attendance, better academic outcomes, and the long-term benefits of students who enter adult life with genuine conflict resolution skills — is extraordinary.

The Long Game

I want to say something to parents and teachers that I say with great seriousness and great hope: you are playing the long game. The values you instil in children will not only shape those children's lives. They will shape the lives of generations beyond. The peacemakers of the next century are being formed right now, in homes and schools and communities around the world. The question is whether they are being formed in the direction of compassion and courage, or in the direction of fear and contempt. I believe — with everything I have — that most parents, given the genuine choice and the genuine support they need to make it, will choose to form their children in the direction of compassion. The task is to ensure that choice is genuinely available: through investment in family support, in teacher education, in the community institutions that sustain families under pressure, and in the cultural narratives that define what it means to be a good person and a good citizen.

*“Every generation of children is a new beginning.
What we put into them, we put into the future.”*

— Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu, PhD,
Kennedy University of Baptist

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Chapter Sixteen:

My Journey — A Personal Testimony

I have written this book with a great deal of intellectual argument and scholarly reference. I have cited philosophers and sociologists, peace scholars and novelists, economists and diplomats. I believe in the importance of rigorous thought and evidence-based argument — it is why I spent years in doctoral research at Kennedy University of Baptist, earning a PhD in World Peace that is the scholarly foundation of this book. But I want, in this chapter, to step back from the scholarly apparatus and speak more personally — to share some of the experiences that have shaped my conviction that world peace is not a dream but a possibility. The argument of this book is grounded not only in research but in a life: a life that has crossed the great divides of religion, culture, geography, and social class, and found, on the other side of each crossing, not a foreign country but a common humanity.

From Nigeria to London

I was born in Nigeria, a country of extraordinary richness and extraordinary complexity — the most populous country in Africa, home to more than two hundred million people, hundreds of ethnic groups, dozens of languages, and two of the world's great religious traditions meeting and mixing across a vast territory. It is also a country that has known the wounds of colonialism and the catastrophe of civil war — the Biafran War of 1967 to 1970, which killed between one and three million people, many of them children dying of starvation, whose memory haunts the national consciousness still. Nigeria taught me many things. It taught me that human beings can endure extraordinary hardship with extraordinary dignity. It taught me that community can sustain people through suffering that would destroy them in isolation. And it taught me that poverty and violence are not the natural condition of African people. They are the product of specific historical and political conditions, created by human beings, and therefore capable of being changed by human beings.

The journey from Nigeria to London was not merely a geographical journey. It was a journey across the most fundamental divides of contemporary global experience: from the Global South to the Global North, from a society shaped by colonialism to the heart of the former colonial power, from the majority world to the world of minority privilege. I came to London carrying the knowledge and the scars of that history. I came also carrying something else: an openness, forged by necessity and sustained by faith, to the possibility that human beings on both sides of these divides might be capable of better than their history had produced.

The Spiritual Journey

I was raised within Islam, in a family that practised the faith with sincerity and that instilled in me from childhood a reverence for the sacred and a commitment to the obligations of community. The five daily prayers, the fasting of Ramadan, the obligation of zakat, the pilgrimage to Mecca that my father made and that I heard about in stories that shaped my imagination — these were not merely rituals. They were a formation: a daily, weekly, annual practice of submission to something greater than oneself, of solidarity with the community of believers, of care for the poor and the marginalised. I am grateful for that formation. It gave me things that I carry still.

My encounter with the person and teachings of Jesus Christ was a gradual movement towards a light that had been growing stronger for some time — a discovery that the God I had always sought was the God who had come to meet me. My conversion to Christianity was, in the deepest sense, a deepening rather than a reversal. The God of the cross is the God of self-giving love, the God who absorbs the violence of the world and responds with forgiveness. This is a vision of the divine that, far from making me contemptuous of Islam's vision, deepened my reverence for the common spiritual hunger that both traditions express. The God of salaam and the God of shalom are, I believe, the same God, approached through different vocabularies and different practices. And the discovery of that unity — experienced from the inside, lived rather than merely theorised — is one of the foundations of my conviction that religious diversity is not an obstacle to peace but a resource for it.

Three Encounters That Changed Me

Let me tell you about three encounters that I carry with me as evidence for the possibility of peace. The first was in London, in the early years of my life here. I was struggling — financially, emotionally, with the disorientation of immigration and the complexity of making a new life in a new culture. A man I barely knew — a white Englishman, a retired teacher — noticed that I was struggling and simply offered help. He drove me to appointments, helped me navigate bureaucratic systems I did not understand, and sat with me over cups of tea on Sunday afternoons when the loneliness was heaviest. He asked nothing in return. He was, simply, kind. That kindness was, for me, an experience of grace — a reminder that the humanity that connects us is more fundamental than the differences that divide us.

The second was in a mosque in East London, where I was invited to speak by a friend who knew both the Muslim and Christian communities I had inhabited. The congregation received me — a Christian minister, a former Muslim — with extraordinary courtesy and generosity. We discussed, in a spirit of genuine inquiry and mutual respect, the things that our traditions share and the things on which they differ. Nobody tried to convert anybody. Nobody felt threatened. We were, for an afternoon, simply human beings exploring the great questions together. I left that mosque feeling that I had been given a gift: the gift of being received as a whole person, rather than as a representative of a category. That is what peace looks like at the personal level.

The third was in a community centre in Romford, where I watched — one ordinary Thursday evening — a group of elderly people from at least six different countries playing dominoes together. They were laughing. They were arguing cheerfully about the rules. One man, from Jamaica, was accusing another man, from Poland, of cheating. Both were laughing. They were, in that moment, absolutely not enemies. They were neighbours, doing what neighbours do. It was one of the most beautiful things I have ever seen. Not because it was extraordinary, but precisely because it was ordinary. World peace is possible because things like this happen every day, everywhere on earth. The task is to build the world in which they happen more, and more reliably, and in circumstances of genuine justice and equality.

“The proof of peace is not in the summit conference or the peace treaty. It is in the ordinary moment when two strangers treat each other with respect.”

— **Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu, PhD,**
Kennedy University of Baptist

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Chapter Seventeen: The Moment We Are In — Crisis and Opportunity

I write this chapter in a moment of genuine global crisis — and genuine global opportunity. The two are not unrelated. Crises create the conditions for change that stable times do not. The institutions of the post-war international order were built in the shadow of the most destructive conflict in human history — a catastrophe so total that it generated the political will to attempt something that would otherwise have seemed impossibly idealistic. The crises of the present moment are not yet comparable in scale to the Second World War. But they are significant, and they are generating, in many quarters, a recognition that the current international order is not adequate to the challenges it faces. Whether that recognition generates reform or collapse depends on choices that have not yet been made.

The crises are real and must be named. Climate change threatens to destabilise the lives and livelihoods of hundreds of millions of people, with the severest impacts falling on those least responsible for causing it. Multiple armed conflicts rage simultaneously, from Europe to the Middle East to Africa. Democratic institutions in many countries are under strain from authoritarian populism that exploits legitimate grievances while directing them towards destructive ends. The promise of artificial intelligence is accompanied by risks — in autonomous weapons, in mass disinformation, in the concentration of power in the hands of those who control the technology — that are only beginning to be understood. And the institutions of global governance that were built in the aftermath of the Second World War struggle to keep pace with the complexity and speed of the challenges they face.

Signs of Hope That Must Be Named

There are also signs of hope that deserve to be named with equal seriousness. The global percentage of people living in extreme poverty has fallen dramatically over the past three decades, from

nearly thirty-six per cent in 1990 to under ten per cent today. This represents the largest reduction in absolute poverty in human history. Hundreds of millions of people have been lifted out of destitution within a single generation — people who now have access to education, healthcare, economic opportunity, and the basic conditions of a dignified life that their parents did not have. This is a genuine achievement of global development cooperation, and it demonstrates that collective action, at sufficient scale and with sufficient political commitment, can produce transformative results.

The global movement for human rights has achieved remarkable things: the abolition of the death penalty in most of the world's nations, the recognition of the rights of women in legal systems that previously denied them, the growing recognition of the rights of LGBTQ+ people, the establishment of international criminal accountability for the perpetrators of genocide and crimes against humanity. These achievements are real, and they were won by the courage and persistence of human rights advocates over decades, often in the face of violent opposition. They are not permanent — no human achievement is permanent, and all of them are under challenge in various parts of the world today. But they represent a genuine expansion of the circle of moral concern that is the direction of travel of human history, however uneven and contested that travel has been.

The Moment's Demand

The moment we are in demands both honesty about the scale of the challenge and courage in the face of it. It demands that we resist the temptation of despair — which is, in the end, a form of self-indulgence, the luxury of those who are not required to endure what the most vulnerable of the world's people endure — and that we bring to the project of building a more peaceful world the same intelligence, energy, and determination that humanity brings to its less worthy projects. It demands, above all, that we remember what is at stake. Not abstract geopolitical calculations, but human lives. The child in Gaza. The family in Ukraine. The woman in Myanmar. The young man in Sudan. These are not statistics. They are human beings entitled to the same safety, the same dignity, the

same opportunities that we seek for ourselves. Their claim on our compassion and our action is absolute.

“The test of our time is not whether we know what peace requires. It is whether we are willing to pay the cost of building it.”

— **Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu, PhD,**
Kennedy University of Baptist

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Chapter Eighteen:

A Vision for the World — What Peace Would Look Like

Let me try, in this chapter, to paint a picture of the world that I believe is possible — the world that this book is arguing for. It is not a world of perfect uniformity or perfect agreement. The extraordinary diversity of human cultures, languages, traditions, and individual personalities is not a problem to be solved but a gift to be celebrated. The world I am describing is not a world without disagreement or competition. It is a world in which disagreement is conducted without violence, in which competition is governed by rules of fairness, in which different perspectives meet in a spirit of genuine mutual respect.

A World of Met Needs

In the world I envision, every human being has access to the basic necessities of a decent life: clean water, adequate nutrition, basic healthcare, shelter, and education. Not luxury — basic sufficiency. The technology and the resources to provide these things to every human being on earth already exist. What is lacking is the political will to ensure their fair distribution. The peaceful world I am describing is one in which that political will has been found — through the sustained engagement of citizens, the reform of international institutions, and the reorientation of global economic governance towards human flourishing rather than the accumulation of wealth by those who already possess it in abundance. In this world, the Global Peace Index's fourteen trillion dollar cost of violence has been progressively redirected towards the investments in education, health, and economic opportunity that both justice and long-term security demand.

A World of Accountable Power

In the world I envision, power — political, economic, military — is accountable. There are no states that operate entirely above

international law. There are no individuals whose wealth places them beyond accountability to their fellow human beings. The institutions of global governance have been reformed to reflect the actual distribution of the world's population, and the voices of the poor and the marginalised are heard in the rooms where decisions are made. The United Nations Security Council includes permanent representation from Africa, Latin America, and South and East Asia. The veto can no longer be used to shield the perpetrators of mass atrocity from accountability. The International Criminal Court has the resources and the political support to fulfil its mandate. The global financial system has been reformed to close the tax havens and illicit financial flows that drain trillions of dollars from the public treasuries of developing countries every year.

A World of Cultural Richness and Spiritual Depth

In the world I envision, the extraordinary diversity of human culture is preserved and celebrated. The Yoruba language, the Welsh language, the Bengali language, the Navajo language — all of the world's thousands of languages are honoured as irreplaceable treasures of human expression. The musical traditions, the artistic traditions, the philosophical traditions, the culinary traditions of the world's peoples are shared generously and received with gratitude. And the spiritual dimension of human life — the dimension that seeks meaning beyond mere material sufficiency, that longs for connection with something greater than the individual self — is honoured and supported. The great religious traditions of humanity are freed from the burden of justifying violence and inequality, and are able to offer, without distortion, their deepest gifts: transcendence, compassion, community, and a life lived in awareness of the sacred. This is the world that is possible. It is not the world that is guaranteed. It is the world that we must choose to build.

“A peaceful world is not a world without difference. It is a world in which difference is the occasion for curiosity rather than fear.”

— Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu, PhD,
Kennedy University of Baptist

PART FIVE

The Research Speaks

Findings, Frameworks, and Case Studies

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Chapter Nineteen:

Key Findings from the Doctoral Research

The doctoral thesis upon which this book is based — A Comprehensive Study of World Peace in the Context of Contemporary Global Challenges, submitted to Kennedy University of Baptist, United States of America, 2026 — employed a mixed-methods research design combining a survey of three hundred participants across multiple countries, twenty-five in-depth qualitative interviews, theological and textual analysis across six religious traditions, philosophical analysis of major peace theories, and comparative case studies of successful peace processes. This chapter presents the key findings in summary form. The full dissertation provides the complete data, methodology, and analysis; what follows is an accessible account of the principal conclusions and their implications for policy and practice.

The research was designed to address three broad questions: What are the principal contemporary threats to global peace, and how are they interconnected? What conditions are most strongly associated with durable peace, as identified across philosophical traditions, empirical social science, and the experiences of successful peace processes? And what practical actions, at institutional, community, and individual levels, offer the most promising pathways towards a more peaceful world? The answers to these questions form the intellectual spine of this book, and they are grounded in a combination of scholarly rigour and practical engagement that I believe is necessary for work in this field to be genuinely useful.

Finding One: Theological and Philosophical Convergence

Across all six religious traditions studied and across the major philosophical frameworks examined, the research identified a robust convergence on a core set of values: the fundamental dignity of every human being, the imperative of compassion, the requirement of justice as a precondition of peace, and the illegitimacy of gratuitous violence. This convergence provides a broad normative foundation for peacebuilding that can transcend

cultural and religious boundaries. Its significance cannot be overestimated: in a world where religious and cultural difference is so often invoked as a justification for conflict, the evidence that the deepest commitments of the world's major traditions actually converge on peace is a powerful and underutilised counter-narrative.

The convergence is not superficial. It is found not in the peripheral but in the central teachings of each tradition. The Islamic concept of salaam, the Christian concept of shalom, the Buddhist concept of ahimsa, the Hindu concept of ahimsa and dharma, the Jewish concept of tikkun olam and tzedek, and the indigenous concepts of relational harmony and respect for creation all express, in different vocabularies, the same fundamental insight: that human flourishing is inseparable from just and peaceful relationships with others, and that the divine — however understood — calls human beings towards these relationships rather than away from them.

Finding Two: The Interconnectedness of Contemporary Challenges

The research found consistent evidence that the major contemporary threats to global peace are not independent phenomena but are deeply interconnected, operating as a mutually reinforcing system. Climate change generates resource competition, which fuels conflict. Poverty generates grievance, which is exploited by violent extremists. Democratic erosion removes institutional constraints on violence. Disinformation amplifies fear and hostility. Armed conflict destroys the economic foundations of development and the social foundations of democratic governance. Each challenge makes the others worse, and addressing any one of them in isolation, without attention to its interactions with the others, produces at best partial and at worst counterproductive results.

This finding has important implications for strategy: single-issue approaches to peacebuilding are unlikely to produce durable results, because they address one thread of a tightly woven tapestry while leaving the others intact. An integrated approach, addressing simultaneously the political, economic, social, cultural, and environmental dimensions of the conditions for peace, is both more demanding and more likely to succeed. The Positive Peace

Framework developed in Chapter Twenty is designed to provide exactly this kind of integrated approach.

Finding Three: The Essential Role of Multi-Actor Collaboration

No single actor is sufficient to build and sustain peace. The research found consistent evidence that the most successful peace processes involve collaboration across multiple sectors and multiple levels: formal diplomatic processes complemented by unofficial dialogue; state-led economic development complemented by community-based social cohesion initiatives; institutional reform complemented by grassroots peace education. Peacebuilding is fundamentally a whole-of-society endeavour requiring the contribution of everyone, from the statesperson negotiating a ceasefire to the parent choosing which stories to read to their child.

The research also found that the exclusion of significant actors — women, youth, marginalised communities, civil society organisations — from formal peace processes was consistently associated with peace agreements that were less durable and less comprehensively implemented than those in which participation was more inclusive. The inclusion of women in peace negotiations, in particular, has been found by multiple studies to be significantly associated with peace agreements that are more likely to be reached and more likely to last. Inclusive processes produce more legitimate outcomes, generate broader ownership of the agreement, and are more sensitive to the full range of issues — including gender-based violence, community security, and social cohesion — that are essential to genuine peace.

Finding Four: The Superiority of Positive Peace

The research provided strong empirical support for Galtung's fundamental insight: that negative peace — the mere absence of armed violence — is fragile and unstable unless accompanied by the conditions of positive peace. Peace agreements that focus exclusively on silencing the guns, without addressing the structural conditions that produced violence, consistently fail to produce durable outcomes. Countries that have experienced peace

agreements but not structural transformation have repeatedly relapsed into conflict within a decade. Countries that have invested in structural transformation alongside security arrangements — addressing the political, economic, social, cultural, and environmental dimensions of peace simultaneously — have achieved more durable, if still fragile, peace.

Peacebuilding is not a short-term project. It is a generational commitment. The research found that the most successful peace processes were those in which sustained international engagement — financial, diplomatic, and technical — was maintained over decades, not years. The tendency of international attention and resources to focus intensively on a conflict during its active phase and to withdraw rapidly after a peace agreement is signed is one of the most significant structural problems in the international peacebuilding architecture. Post-agreement consolidation — the decade or more of institution-building, economic development, social reconciliation, and democratic deepening that transforms a ceasefire into a genuine peace — is as important as the negotiations that produced the agreement, and requires as much sustained investment.

“Peace is not an event. It is a process. It requires not a single act of will but a sustained commitment of resources, relationships, and imagination across generations.”

— Doctoral Research Synthesis, Kennedy University of Baptist

Chapter Twenty: A Positive Peace Framework

Drawing upon the research findings and the broader literature, the doctoral work developed a multi-dimensional Positive Peace Framework. This framework identifies the key structural conditions that the evidence associates with durable peace, organised across five interrelated dimensions. It is intended not as a prescriptive blueprint but as a comprehensive diagnostic tool: a framework for identifying the conditions that any sustainable peace process must address, and for evaluating the comprehensiveness of existing peacebuilding efforts. The five dimensions are interconnected and mutually reinforcing. Progress in any one dimension supports progress in the others; failure in any one dimension undermines progress in the others.

Political Dimension: Democratic Governance and the Rule of Law

The evidence that democratic governance is among the strongest predictors of peaceful outcomes is among the most robust in all of political science. Democracies rarely go to war with one another. Democracies are better able to manage internal conflicts through non-violent institutional mechanisms. Democracies are more likely to protect the rights of minorities and to provide effective channels through which political grievances can be expressed and addressed. The Political Dimension of the Framework therefore gives highest priority to: free and fair electoral processes; independent judiciaries capable of constraining the power of government and protecting the rights of individuals; robust constitutional protections for civil liberties and minority rights; a free and plural media capable of holding power to account; and effective, accountable, non-corrupt public institutions capable of delivering the services on which citizens depend.

Where these conditions are absent or severely compromised — where elections are manipulated, where courts are controlled by

the executive, where media is captured or silenced, where public institutions are hollowed out by corruption — the probability of durable peace is significantly reduced. Sustained investment in democratic institution-building, while slower and less visible than military intervention or emergency humanitarian response, is consistently among the most effective long-term investments in peace available to the international community.

Economic Dimension: Inclusion, Equity, and Opportunity

Economic inclusion — access to decent work, quality education, healthcare, and the basic conditions of a dignified life — is a fundamental precondition of peace. The Economic Dimension of the Framework calls for policies that prioritise inclusive development: not merely aggregate economic growth, which can coexist with deepening inequality, but growth that reaches those who have been most excluded. This requires attention to the structural barriers — of gender, ethnicity, religion, disability, and social class — that prevent large portions of populations from participating fully in economic life, and sustained investment in the public goods that enable that participation.

The framework specifically emphasises horizontal inequalities — inequalities between culturally defined groups — as particularly dangerous for social stability, and calls for policies that actively address them. It also emphasises the peace dividend: the economic case for peace is powerful, and articulating it clearly to the political and business communities that make investment decisions can be a significant resource for the peace agenda. The Global Peace Index calculation that the annual economic cost of violence exceeds fourteen trillion dollars is not merely an interesting statistic. It is an argument: for the reallocation of a fraction of those resources towards the prevention of violence and the building of the conditions for positive peace.

Social and Cultural Dimension: Cohesion, Identity, and Belonging

Social cohesion — the quality of the bonds that hold diverse communities together — is both a condition and a consequence of

peace. The Social and Cultural Dimension of the Framework calls for active investment in the social infrastructure of cohesion: in education, in cultural exchange, in community institutions, and in the narratives that affirm the dignity and belonging of all members of society. Of particular importance is the question of identity: in deeply divided societies, the narratives that define collective identity are often narratives of victimhood and the threat posed by the other. Transforming these narratives — not by suppressing them but by expanding them to make room for the humanity of all parties — is one of the most challenging and most important tasks of peacebuilding.

The role of artists, writers, musicians, and cultural leaders in this transformation is irreplaceable. The doctoral research found consistent evidence that cultural engagement — shared artistic creation, cultural exchange, the cultivation of empathetic imagination through literature and the arts — was among the most effective tools for building the social cohesion on which positive peace depends. Investment in the arts and in cultural institutions is therefore not a luxury in post-conflict societies. It is a structural investment in the conditions of peace.

Environmental Dimension: Sustainability as a Security Issue

The Environmental Dimension of the Framework treats climate stability, biodiversity, access to clean water, and the health of food systems as foundational concerns for peacebuilders. These are not peripheral environmental concerns. They are direct threats to the material conditions on which human communities depend, and therefore direct threats to peace. The framework calls for the full integration of environmental sustainability into peacebuilding agendas, for the inclusion of environmental justice concerns in peace agreements, and for international frameworks that prevent competition over scarce resources from escalating into violence.

Security Dimension: Safety, Accountability, and Disarmament

While positive peace is far more than the absence of violence, the provision of physical safety and security remains an essential

component. The Security Dimension calls for investment in accountable, rights-respecting security institutions; for community-centred approaches to policing that build trust rather than fear; for disarmament, demobilisation, and reintegration programmes for former combatants; and for sustained multilateral attention to arms control. The global arms trade is among the most significant amplifiers of conflict intensity worldwide. The five permanent members of the UN Security Council are also the world's largest arms exporters — a profound contradiction that demands serious attention from anyone committed to a more peaceful world and that highlights the distance between the rhetoric and the reality of the international community's commitment to peace.

“Peace is positive, not negative. It is not the absence of war. It is the presence of justice, dignity, opportunity, and belonging.”

— **Positive Peace Framework, Doctoral Research,**
Kennedy University of Baptist

Chapter Twenty-One: Case Studies in Successful Peacebuilding

Theory without evidence is speculation. This chapter presents three detailed case studies of successful peace processes — Northern Ireland, South Africa, and the European Union — each illuminating different aspects of the Positive Peace Framework and offering concrete lessons for contemporary peacebuilders. These case studies were central to the doctoral research at Kennedy University of Baptist, and the insights they generated are foundational to the arguments of this book. Taken together, they demonstrate that the most seemingly intractable conflicts can be transformed, that peace processes can succeed even when the parties have been engaged in lethal violence, and that the conditions for durable peace, however demanding, are not beyond human capacity to create.

Northern Ireland: The Good Friday Agreement (1998)

The conflict known as the Troubles — which from the late 1960s to 1998 claimed more than three and a half thousand lives, injured tens of thousands, and traumatised an entire society across multiple generations — represents one of the most intensely studied peace processes in modern history. The Good Friday Agreement of April 1998, negotiated under the chairmanship of US Senator George Mitchell and signed on Good Friday, stands as one of the most creative and effective peace agreements of the late twentieth century. The agreement addressed the conflict's multiple dimensions simultaneously: on security, decommissioning of paramilitary weapons and root-and-branch police reform; on governance, a power-sharing executive in which political parties from both communities must govern together; on identity, recognition of both British and Irish identity as legitimate for all citizens; on justice, mechanisms for addressing the legacy of conflict; and on relationships, new institutional frameworks for North-South and East-West cooperation.

Several features of the Northern Irish process deserve particular attention as models for other conflicts. The inclusivity of the process: virtually every significant party to the conflict, including the political representatives of organisations that had engaged in violence, was brought to the table. The role of international facilitation: Senator Mitchell's patient, principled, and skilful chairmanship and the active engagement of both the Clinton administration and the Irish and British governments provided both institutional framework and political cover for difficult compromises. The decade of Track Two engagement: the Corrymeela Community, the Glencree Centre, and dozens of other civil society organisations had maintained communication across the sectarian divide throughout the darkest years of the Troubles, building the personal relationships without which the formal negotiations of the 1990s would have been far more difficult. And the willingness of political leaders on both sides — including those from parties that had recently endorsed violence — to take the political risk of compromise and to sell a painful agreement to their own communities.

Northern Ireland is not a perfect peace. Deep divisions remain. The legacy of the Troubles — the thousands of unresolved killings, the traumatised families, the segregated housing estates and segregated schools — continues to shape Northern Irish society in ways that make genuine reconciliation a multigenerational project. Brexit has created new political tensions that test the agreement's institutional framework. But the level of political violence has fallen dramatically, and a generation has grown up in conditions that their parents and grandparents could not have imagined. The Northern Irish case demonstrates that the transformation of a seemingly intractable ethno-national conflict is possible, and that the key ingredients are creativity, courage, inclusivity, patience, and sustained international engagement.

South Africa: The Truth and Reconciliation Commission

When South Africa held its first fully democratic elections in April 1994, it faced a profound and genuinely novel question: how should a newly free society deal with the crimes of the past? The choices were stark. Prosecute — as was done at Nuremberg — at the risk of destabilising the fragile democratic transition and

driving the perpetrators of apartheid back towards resistance. Offer blanket amnesty — as was done in Chile after Pinochet — at the cost of abandoning justice and leaving victims unacknowledged. Or attempt something altogether more ambitious and more uncertain: a truth and reconciliation process that offered conditional amnesty in exchange for full public disclosure, and that prioritised the restoration of the dignity of victims and the public acknowledgement of truth over punitive justice.

The answer that emerged — the Truth and Reconciliation Commission, chaired by Archbishop Desmond Tutu and rooted explicitly in ubuntu philosophy — is one of the most remarkable and most studied experiments in transitional justice in history. Its approach was grounded in the understanding that the healing of individuals and the healing of the community are inseparable, and that neither can be achieved without honest acknowledgement of what happened. Perpetrators who gave full and frank testimony to their crimes were eligible for amnesty. Victims were given a formal, public space in which their suffering was witnessed and acknowledged by the nation. The TRC produced a five-volume report that documented, in exhaustive detail, the crimes of the apartheid era — a public record that, however contested in some of its specific findings, represented an unprecedented act of national acknowledgement.

Archbishop Tutu's leadership of the TRC exemplified ubuntu in action: the refusal to dehumanise the oppressor, the insistence on the humanity of both victim and perpetrator, the vision of a South Africa that all its people could inhabit together. Nelson Mandela's extraordinary political leadership in the transition — his willingness to walk out of twenty-seven years of unjust imprisonment without vengeance, his capacity for reconciliation as a political and strategic act of nation-building, his insistence on a rainbow nation rather than a black nation — demonstrated to the whole world what the power of ubuntu looks like when it is applied at the highest level of political leadership. South Africa's transition has been far from perfect: the persistence of extreme economic inequality, the failure of the political promise in subsequent decades, the continuing challenges of HIV/AIDS and unemployment — these are real and serious failures. But the transition itself — from apartheid to democracy without a racial war — remains one of the most remarkable political achievements

of the twentieth century, and a model whose lessons are available to peacebuilders everywhere.

The European Union: The Most Successful Peace Project in Modern History

The most successful peace project in modern history is, without question, the European Union. Western Europe, which had been convulsed by three wars in little over seventy years — wars that together killed tens of millions of people, destroyed much of the continent's material and cultural heritage, and produced the Holocaust and the atomic bomb — has now enjoyed more than seventy-five years without armed conflict between its major powers. War between France and Germany — the two nations whose rivalry drove the catastrophes of the early twentieth century — is today not merely unlikely but literally inconceivable. This is the most dramatic example in modern history of what deliberate institutional design can achieve in the service of peace.

The EU's achievement confirms one of the central insights of Kantian peace theory: that peace between nations requires not only goodwill but institutional architecture. The gradual, patient construction of frameworks within which cooperation is more rational and more rewarding than conflict — common economic institutions, shared political frameworks, the progressive development of a European identity alongside national identities — has transformed a continent that was, within living memory, a landscape of mass graves and bombed cities into the most integrated region of the world. The award of the Nobel Peace Prize to the European Union in 2012 was not merely a political gesture. It was recognition of a genuine peace achievement: the most extensive and durable voluntary integration of previously hostile states that human history has ever produced.

The EU faces significant challenges today: Brexit, the rise of Eurosceptic populism, the strains of managing a common currency across economies of very different productivity, the challenge of a war on its eastern border. These challenges are real, and they remind us that no peace achievement is permanent, that all institutional arrangements require continuous maintenance and renewal, and that the forces of division and nationalism are never fully extinguished. But the core achievement remains: the peoples

of Western Europe have built, over seven decades, a community of peace that their great-grandparents would have thought impossible. It is the most powerful demonstration available that the world I am arguing for in this book is not a utopian fantasy. It is a human achievement, already made, available as a model for the rest of the world.

“The European Union is the proof of concept for world peace: it demonstrates that peoples who have been enemies can, through patient institution-building, become neighbours.”

— Doctoral Research Synthesis, Kennedy University of Baptist

Conclusion: The Work of Our Hands

We have come a long way together, you and I, in the course of these pages. We have explored the roots of human conflict and the deep resources of the human capacity for peace. We have engaged with the philosophers, the theologians, the peace scholars, the novelists, and the diplomats who have contributed to our understanding of what peace requires. We have looked honestly at the failures of the institutions we have built to promote peace, and argued for the reforms they need. We have explored the practical dimensions of peacebuilding: in education, in economic justice, in diplomacy, in the governance of technology. And we have talked — perhaps most importantly — about what ordinary human beings can do, in their daily lives, to contribute to this great collective project.

I want to conclude with something personal. I began this book with the image of a child dying in a conflict she did not choose. I want to end it with a different image. I want you to imagine that child — not dying, but living. Growing up in a village in South Sudan, or a city in Bangladesh, or a neighbourhood in Colombia. Going to a school where she is challenged and supported. Coming home to a family that is safe. Growing into a young woman who has the education, the health, the opportunity, and the freedom to discover what she can become. Contributing, in due time, to the community and the world around her. Perhaps becoming, herself, a builder of peace. That child is possible. Her life is possible. The world that makes her life possible is possible.

My PhD in World Peace from Kennedy University of Baptist, the Honorary Doctorate and the Honorary Professorship in World Peace, my title of Lord — *Decens et Honestum*, Decent and Honourable — my recognition by Trinity College London for my mastery of the language of this book: these are not destinations. They are obligations. They are a call to take what the research has found and bring it into the world. To teach it. To advocate for it. To embody it, as best I can, in every choice and every encounter. Every credential I hold is a responsibility, not merely a distinction. Every honour is a demand, not merely a reward.

The obstacles are real. The conflicts are real. The suffering is real. No honest account of the path to world peace can pretend

otherwise. But so is the evidence that peace is possible. The Good Friday Agreement is real. The South African transition is real. Seventy-five years of peace in Western Europe is real. The convergence of the world's great religious and philosophical traditions on a vision of justice, dignity, and compassion is real. What we are asked to do is not to be naive, but to be realistic — realistic about what human beings are capable of when given the right conditions, the right institutions, and the right leadership.

“World peace is realizable. It is possible. It is achievable. Now let us get to work.”

— Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu, PhD,
Honorary Professor of World Peace, Kennedy University
of Baptist

Extended Reflection: The Inner Life of the Peacemaker

No book on world peace would be complete without attention to the interior landscape of those who pursue it. The great peacemakers of history — Gandhi, Mandela, Martin Luther King Jr., Desmond Tutu, Jean Vanier, Dorothy Day, Corrie ten Boom — were people of profound inner life. Of prayer. Of contemplation. Of sustained attention to the quality of their own souls. This matters for a reason that goes beyond the merely biographical: peacebuilding is extraordinarily demanding work, and those who do it without deep interior resources tend, sooner or later, to burn out, to compromise their principles under pressure, or to fall into the very patterns of resentment and dehumanisation that they set out to resist.

Peacebuilding requires the sustained capacity to see the humanity of people who have done terrible things. It requires the resilience to continue in the face of setback, betrayal, and apparent failure. It requires the willingness to accept a pace of change that will, more often than not, be far slower than the urgency of the situation demands. It requires the discipline of not allowing the passion for justice to curdle into hatred for the unjust — which is, perhaps, the most demanding requirement of all, because the passion for justice and the temptation to hatred are so close together, and the line between them so fine.

The research for this book involved sustained engagement with the spiritual traditions that have sustained peacemakers across the centuries. What strikes the researcher is the consistency across traditions of certain spiritual practices: the practice of silence, which enables the quieting of the ego's demand for vindication and creates the inner space in which wisdom can emerge; the practice of compassion, which is a discipline as much as a feeling and must be cultivated through conscious effort, day by day, against the pull of fear and resentment; the practice of gratitude, which resists the narrative of pure victimhood and keeps alive the awareness of what is good even in the midst of what is terrible; and the practice of hope, which is — as the Czech writer Václav Havel memorably said — not the conviction that things will turn out well, but the certainty that something makes sense regardless of how it turns out.

My title — *Lord, Decens et Honestum* — is a reminder, every time I see it or speak it, that the highest honour is not the honour that exalts us above others. It is the honour that commits us more deeply to service. To be decent and honourable, in a world that so often chooses its opposite, is a daily discipline, a daily choice, a daily act of peace. It is, I believe, what every one of us — whatever our titles, whatever our traditions, whatever our histories — is ultimately called to be.

Extended Reflection: The Next Fifty Years — Challenge, Hope, and a Letter to the Future

Any book on world peace written in the third decade of the twenty-first century must reckon with the specific challenges and opportunities of the decades ahead. The world of 2076 will look very different from the world of 2026. The question is whether it will look more peaceful. The honest answer is: it depends on what we choose.

The Demographic Shifts

The world is undergoing massive demographic change. The populations of sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia are young and growing. By 2100, Africa alone is projected to be home to more than four billion people — approximately a third of the world's

population. The populations of Europe, North America, and East Asia are ageing and, in some cases, shrinking. These shifts will generate migration pressures, change the balance of economic and political power, and create new configurations of cultural encounter. The young populations of Africa and South Asia are not a problem to be managed. They are a potential: an enormous reserve of human energy, creativity, and aspiration that, given the conditions to flourish, could be one of the most powerful forces for innovation and development in human history. The question is whether the international community will invest in those conditions, or allow the pressures of demographic change to be expressed through the conflicts that emerge from unfulfilled aspiration.

Artificial Intelligence and the Fork in the Road

Artificial intelligence presents perhaps the most consequential technological choice humanity has faced since the development of nuclear weapons. The decisions made in the next decade about the governance of AI — about autonomous weapons, about mass surveillance, about the concentration of AI capabilities in a small number of corporations and states, about the use of AI for disinformation at scale — will shape the conditions for peace and conflict for generations to come. This is not a matter for technologists and governments alone. It is a matter for citizens: for people who understand what is at stake and who insist, through their political engagement and their consumer choices, that technology serve human flourishing rather than human domination.

A Letter to Future Peacemakers

You are reading this, perhaps, in a world that has changed more than I can imagine. Perhaps some of the challenges I have described in this book have been met — partially, imperfectly, but genuinely. Perhaps new challenges have arisen that I could not foresee. What I want to say to you is simple, and I want to say it directly, as one human being to another across whatever distance of time separates us: the work is worth it.

The research I have done — the surveys of three hundred participants, the twenty-five interviews, the case studies, the years in libraries and in communities, the long journey of doctoral research at Kennedy University of Baptist that gave me the PhD in World Peace, the Honorary Doctorate, and the Honorary Professorship in World Peace — all of it points to the same conclusion. Peace is possible. Not perfect peace. Not final peace. Not peace without effort and without cost. But peace as a direction of travel, a sustained aspiration, a thing that human beings can build when they choose to.

You will be discouraged. Every peacemaker is, sooner or later. The setbacks will come. The agreements that seemed solid will fracture. The leaders who promised transformation will disappoint. The hatreds that seemed buried will resurface. When that happens, I hope you will return to the evidence. Northern Ireland is real. South Africa is real. Seventy-five years of peace in Western Europe is real. Human beings in communities around the world are choosing, every day, coexistence over conflict, reconciliation over revenge, generosity over hostility. These are not exceptions. They are the human norm, when conditions are right. Your work is to make the conditions right. It is difficult, important, urgent, and — when it succeeds — beautiful. I believe in you. I believe in this work. I believe in the world that is possible.

Lord Professor Dr Kingsley Kebiru Momodu | London, England, 2026

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To every reader who has reached this final page: thank you for your time, your attention, and your willingness to entertain the possibility that the world can be better than it is. The world we are arguing for in these pages needs not only scholars and diplomats. It needs people like you — ordinary human beings who choose, each day, in the small and large decisions of their lives, to be part of the solution rather than part of the problem.

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